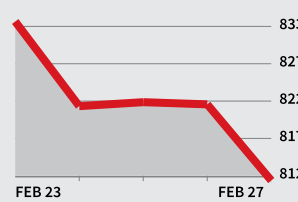


the hindu businessline

SENSEX 81287.19 (-961.42)



IN FOCUS

	LATEST	CHANGE
Nifty 50	25178.65	-317.90
P/E Ratio (Sensex)	22.32	-0.26
US Dollar (in ₹)	90.97	+0.07
Gold Std 10 gm (in ₹)	158460.00	+1071
Silver 1 kg (in ₹)	266700.00	+6033

GROWTH ROADMAP.

We aim to grow assets and liabilities in line with market in FY27; gain market share in FY28, says Rajiv Anand, MD & CEO, IndusInd Bank **p9**



AUTO FOCUS.

BMW X3 xDrive30 M Sport Pro blends bold design, performance refinement and capability **p4**

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QUICKLY.

AT ₹9.8 LAKH CRORE
April-January fiscal deficit hits 63% of FY26 target



New Delhi: Fiscal deficit for the first 10 months (April-January) of the current fiscal stood at ₹9.8 lakh crore, or 63 per cent of the annual Budget Estimates, the Controller General of Accounts (CGA) said on Wednesday. It was 74.5 per cent during the corresponding period of the last fiscal. The Centre estimates the fiscal deficit (the gap between expenditure and revenue) during 2025-26 at 4.4 per cent of GDP, or ₹15.58 lakh crore. **p5**

at all state

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GDP growth for FY27 revised to 7-7.4% with 'upward risk'

NEW SERIES. Economy expanded 7.8% in Q3; FY26 fiscal deficit projected a tad higher

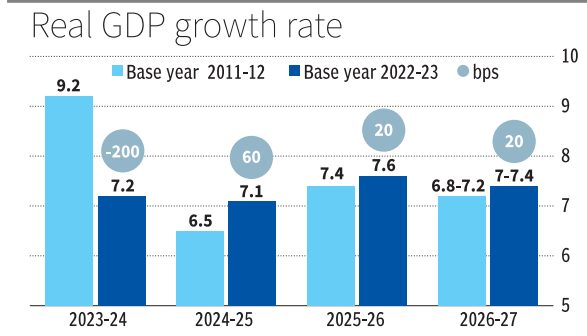
Shishir Sinha
New Delhi

With the change in the base year and the methodology for calculating the Gross Domestic Product (GDP), Chief Economic Advisor V Anantha Nageswaran on Friday revised upward the growth estimates for fiscal year 2026-27 by 20 basis points. Simultaneously, he raised the fiscal deficit projection for the current fiscal year by 10 basis points.

The new base year for GDP calculation has now been revised to 2022-23 from 2011-12. The Statistics Ministry has also revised the real GDP growth rate for fiscal years 2023-24, 2024-25 and 2025-26.

In a media briefing, the Chief Economic Advisor said, "Economic Survey's projection for FY27 has been revised upward to 7-7.4 per cent under the new series." Earlier, it was 6.8-7.2 per cent.

"The new estimates are with an upward risk. This means the economy is more likely to achieve a number closer to 7.4 per cent rather than 7 per cent," he said.



Source: MoSPI, Economic Survey

Further, he said that the economy continues to maintain strong growth momentum, supported by broad-based economic sectors. Favourable supply-side conditions, including robust rabi sowing, comfortable foodgrains stocks and easing global commodity prices, are expected to keep inflation low and stable.

"Fiscal consolidation is on track, with the fiscal deficit estimated at 4.5 per cent of GDP for 2025-26, under the new series, without compromising on capital expenditure," he said.

Earlier, the revised fiscal deficit was 4.4 per cent of GDP, but it has been revised upward due to the change in

nominal growth. However, when asked about a revision in the Budget Estimates of the fiscal deficit for the current fiscal year, which is pegged at 4.3 per cent of GDP, Anantha Nageswaran refused to comment. He highlighted that the per capita nominal GDP growth could reach 9 per cent, noting that in recent years, the per capita real income growth has averaged about 6.8 per cent.

GDP GROWTH REVISION

The Statistics and Programme Implementation Ministry revised the GDP growth estimate for the current fiscal year to 7.6 per cent from 7.4 per cent after the change in the base year and

the addition of data from GST and the e-Vahan portal to better reflect economic activity.

According to the new series, GDP in the October-December quarter grew by 7.8 per cent, up from 7.4 per cent in the year-ago period, mainly driven by the manufacturing and services sectors. Further, GDP growth for the second quarter has been revised upwards to 8.4 per cent from 8.2 per cent in the old series (base: 2011-12). For the first quarter, it has been lowered to 6.7 per cent from 7.8 per cent.

Anantha Nageswaran also said the momentum in the economy is good enough to deliver a growth rate of 7.3 per cent or more so that FY26 growth estimates of 7.6 per cent are achieved.

"Real GDP or GDP at Constant Prices is estimated to hit ₹322.58 lakh crore in FY26, against the First Revised Estimate of GDP for 2024-25 of ₹299.89 lakh crore. The growth rate in Real GDP during 2025-26 is estimated at 7.6 per cent compared to 7.1 per cent in 2024-25," the Statistics Ministry said, releasing the new series.

'More reforms needed to empower women in the rural economy'

Subramani Ra Mancombu
New Delhi

Though the role of women in agriculture is changing from drudgery and hard labour to more systematic working, it is still not enough to bring real transformation in the rural economy.

Women are the real beneficiaries of schemes to provide water and electricity or the Swachh Bharat mission, but they need to be empowered by ensuring the availability of basic amenities across all sectors, said Devesh Chaturvedi, Secretary, Department of Agriculture and Farmers' Welfare, inaugurating *businessline's* fifth Agri and Commodity Summit in New Delhi on Friday.

More women have become members of farmer-producer organisations (FPO) thanks to the changes in land laws, he added.

5 IMPORTANT SHIFTS

"Initially, in agriculture, land laws did not give women the ownership rights. But, now, most States have changed their laws, and most women are getting the ownership of land," Chaturvedi said on the theme of the summit, 'Women: The Pillar of Rural Economy'. *businessline* is the first major platform to commem-



Devesh Chaturvedi, Secretary, Department of Agriculture and Farmers' Welfare, at the inaugural session of the *businessline* Agri and Commodity Summit 2026, in New Delhi **BUJO GHOSH**

orate the 'Year of Women Farmer', declared by the UN.

In his special address, Nabard Chairman Shaji KV identified five important structural shifts that should happen, one of which is the formal recognition of women as farmers. He said the government had come up with several initiatives so that women can own farms.

Women play a key role in dairying, whose value has exceeded that of grains, pulses and other crops, said Brahmani Nara, Executive Director, Heritage Foods. "Women are the guardians of nutrition and nourishment," she said in a fireside chat with *businessline* Editor Raghuvir Srinivasan.

ROLE REVERSAL

Calling for a major role reversal of the "silent archi-

tecs of the rural economy, speakers across various panels said their contribution in the field needs to be recognised.

Sanjiv Kanwar, MD, Yara South Asia and Country Head of Yara India, said in a panel discussion that 50-70 per cent of women farmers don't have land titles in their name.

In another panel, Ajay Kumar Jha, Deputy GM, Product Development and Marketing, SBI, called for motivating woman farmers to migrate up the value chain.

Nabard was the presenting sponsor of the summit, while the associate sponsors were Yara India, Indofill Industries Ltd, Bayer, HURL and Markfed Punjab. State Bank of India was the banking partner, and Agri Network Consultancy the media partner.

More reports on p2,p3

India-US trade deal can be re-balanced with changed situation post tariff ruling: Goyal

Amiti Sen
New Delhi

Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal has signalled the possibility of a "re-balancing" of the India-US trade deal framework amid the changed circumstances following the US Supreme Court invalidating the reciprocal duties imposed by the Donald Trump regime.

The Minister said India is in "wait-and-watch" mode but wants to continue to engage with the US for the "best possible opportunities" in the deal.

DEAL EQUILIBRIUM

"...You must have read the joint statement that we have finalised with the US. It has categorically said that should the circumstances change, the deal would be re-balanced to make sure the balance of the deal is maintained on both



Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal

sides," the Minister stated in his address at a media event on Friday.

The February 6 joint statement on the India-US interim trade deal framework said the US would cut reciprocal tariffs on India to 18 per cent, while India would reduce or eliminate tariffs on all US industrial goods and a number of agricultural products, including DDGS, red sorghum, fruits, nuts, soybean oil, wine and spirits. However, the US re-

ciprocal tariffs have since been replaced with a 10 per cent short-term global levy on all countries (likely to be increased to 15 per cent soon).

As a result, instead of facing a 50 per cent tariff (later reduced to 25 per cent after the Russian oil penalty was withdrawn), Indian goods now face just a 10-15 per cent tariff, in line with other countries. Many trade experts have argued that there is no point now in India giving tariff con-

cessions to the US if it does not get any additional cuts in return.

EDGE ON COMPETITION

However, Goyal said the trade deal is not only about tariffs but also about the competitive advantage over others. While India did not send its trade negotiating team to the US this week as scheduled as it was "evaluating the situation", US Commerce Secretary Howard Lutnick was in New Delhi on Thursday on a private visit, and met Goyal.

Details of the meeting were not officially shared by either side, but sources said the US was keen on keeping the trade talks on track.

India's perceived gains on tariffs (with the promised 18 per cent somewhat lower than that of Bangladesh, Vietnam and Indonesia's 19-20 per cent) have been evened out post the court order.

Beyond tariffs, India-EU FTA text covers services, sustainability, IPR, digital trade

Amiti Sen
New Delhi

Marking a significant shift in the depth of economic engagement, the Free Trade Agreement between India and the European Union introduces far-reaching commitments on sustainability and labour, intellectual property rights (trademark and copyright), services and digital trade, areas that had long remained sticking points in the negotiations.

CBAM STATUS QUO

The text of the India-EU Free Trade Agreement released by the European Union on Friday makes it clear that for Carbon Border Adjustment Measures (CBAM), no special provision has been made for India, but it has been assured that if any concession is given to a third country, the



The new provisions move the partnership beyond tariffs into regulatory alignment

same shall apply to India.

"Both India and EU shall apply no less favourable conditions to the other party's goods than those applied to like goods from other third countries as regards any flexibilities granted in the implementation of their carbon border adjustment measures," said the text of the FTA. The new provisions move the partnership decis-

ively beyond tariff reduction into regulatory alignment and rule-setting across key sectors.

SERVICES ACCESS

In services, the pact provides for improved market access commitments across sectors such as IT, financial services, telecommunications and professional services, alongside provisions on temporary movement of skilled professionals. The digital trade chapter includes commitments to facilitate cross-border data flows for business purposes while preserving each side's right to regulate for privacy and security.

It bars Customs duties on electronic transmissions and discourages forced disclosure of source code, except for legitimate regulatory review. Provisions on electronic authentication and e-signatures aim to smooth digital

commerce, an area of expanding bilateral trade.

IP SAFEGUARDS

On intellectual property rights, the agreement strengthens enforcement standards, covering trademarks, copyrights, designs and patents. It provides enhanced protection for geographical indications (GIs), opening the door for expanded recognition of European food and beverage names in India and Indian specialty products in EU markets.

The text also contains commitments on border enforcement to curb counterfeit goods and improve cooperation between Customs authorities.

The sustainable development chapter binds both sides to effectively implement their obligations under international labour and environmental conventions.

Women power — cultivating success through collectives

A new rural revolution is happening with women 'agripreneurs' banding together to overcome barriers

Rohit Vaid
New Delhi

Their stories of how they ignored taunts, balanced housework and care duties and trained to become successful farmers brought the audience up on its feet to give a standing ovation.

When Aruna Debbarma, a *Lakshpati Didi* from Tripura under the Tripura Rural Livelihood Mission, said, "Earlier, I used to hear taunts for going out to attend training and work, but now I get compliments. Today, I train around 400 women on vermi-compost and agricultural techniques for natural farming," the applause became thunderous.

Equally powerful was the way Vaishali Gugre, Member, Swayam Shikshan Prayod, shared her struggles-to-success story

and how she started from zero. "But today I have a business of around ₹60 lakh with a turnover of around ₹12 lakh in a year."

Gugre and Debbarma were speaking at a session, *From Fieldwork to Enterprise* at the *businessline* Agri and Commodity Summit 2026, moderated by Richa Mishra, the paper's Resident Editor in Hyderabad. Their stories revealed how women no longer plough a lonely furrow in the fields. And how natural farming and woman-led collectives are gathering momentum across rural India, finally breaking the soil ceiling.

MARKET ACCESS

The session, however, brought to the fore the challenges women face. Both of them rued the absence of assured markets and fair pri-



(from left) Richa Mishra, Resident Editor, *businessline*; Aruna Debbarma, *Lakshpati Didi*, Tripura Rural Livelihood Mission, and Vaishali Gugre, Member, Swayam Shikshan Prayog, at the *businessline* Agri and Commodity Summit **BUJO GHOSH**

cing. "Production is not the main problem anymore," said Debbarma, stressing, "We need better markets and structured support for our groups."

Besides, she noted that much of the produce is still sold locally, with limited government procurement or supply chain backing.

Similar concerns were raised by Ghuge from Maharashtra's Dharashiv district, where she helped launch a women-led farmer producer company (FPC) in 2017. At present, nine such women-led FPCs operate across eight blocks in the district, facilitating collective buying and selling.

"Market access, price stability, supply systems and low-interest loans — these are the four pillars we need," she said, adding that scaling up remains difficult despite rising output.

Both agripreneurs pointed out that most rural women do not hold land titles in their names, making it difficult for them to get formal loans.

Ghuge said when their FPC was formed, many women had to obtain holding letters from male family members to access credit and complete formalities. Both called for easier access to low-interest loans, formal recognition of women as farmers, and stronger institutional backing for collective enterprises.

ROLE OF SHGs

Beyond policy gaps, both ag-

ripreneurs highlighted the transformative role of self-help groups (SHGs) in their journeys.

According to them, their transition began with small monthly savings through SHGs and access to modest loans, which enabled them to start farming, rearing livestock and allied activities on a limited scale before expanding into organised enterprises.

They added that training interventions through Krishi Vigyan Kendras (KVKs) had improved productivity, with the primary constraint now shifting from production to post-harvest market linkages.

In addition, they noted that increased financial participation had enabled women to take on leadership roles within collectives and train other farmers.

Sensex plunges 961 points, Nifty slips below 25,200 on broad-based sell-off

Anupama Ghosh
Mumbai

Markets ended the week on a deeply negative note with the BSE Sensex crashing 961.42 points on Friday to close at 81,287.19, while the NSE Nifty50 shed 317.90 points to settle at 25,178.65, dropping below the psychologically significant 25,200 mark and slipping below its 200-day EMA, a key long-term trend indicator, signalling that sellers are firmly in control.

The breakdown was sharp and broad-based as traders preferred a risk-off trading strategy due to the escalation of geopolitical tension involving Iran.

Of the 4,369 stocks traded on the BSE, 2,633 declined against 1,574 advances, while 340 stocks hit fresh 52-week lows compared to just 100

The Nifty Midcap 100 and Nifty Smallcap 100 indices slipped 1.14% and 1.10%, respectively

reaching new highs. Six stocks were locked in the lower circuit. The Nifty Midcap 100 and Nifty Smallcap 100 indices slipped 1.14 per cent and 1.10 per cent, respectively.

Foreign institutional investors were aggressive sellers on the day, with FIIs/FPIs recording a provisional net sell of ₹7,536.36 crore in the cash segment. Domestic institutional investors, however, provided a significant counterweight, logging a net buy of ₹12,292.81 crore.

Read more on p8

‘Women in farm sector will move from drudgery to decision-making’

MUCH-NEEDED LIFELINE. The government is focused on mechanisation of tasks primarily performed by women: Devesh Chaturvedi, Secretary, Department of Agriculture & Farmers’ Welfare

Our Bureau
New Delhi

The government is focused on changing the role of women in agriculture from one defined by drudgery and hard labour to more systematic, mechanised and organised work, with a stronger shift towards decision-making and entrepreneurship, said Devesh Chaturvedi, Secretary of the Department of Agriculture & Farmers’ Welfare.

LAKHPATI DIDI INITIATIVE
The government is doubling its target for the *Lakhpati Didi* initiative, aiming to empower six crore women in villages to earn an annual income of at least ₹1 lakh within the next five years, said Chaturvedi at the *businessline* Agriculture and Commodity Summit on Friday.
“One of the first decisions taken by the PM when he entered the Seva Teerth was to increase *Lakhpati Didis* from three crore to six crore. So, in the next five years, we will have six crore women in villages earning more than a lakh [rupees] every year. That will again bring a lot of empowerment for women,” he said.

FUTURE POLICIES ARE KEY
To support this, future policies will prioritise the mechanisation of tasks typically performed by women to further reduce physical drudgery and improve overall health, he added.
The Secretary traced the evolution of women in the primary sector, noting that while they have historically performed the most tedious work in agriculture and animal husbandry, their roles are finally being formalised and made less dreary.

LAND OWNERSHIP
This transformation is being driven by several key pillars, prominent among which has been the ownership of rural land by women.
“In agriculture, initially the land laws were such that women did not get ownership of rural land,” said Chaturvedi.
“Now, most States have changed their laws and most women do get ownership of land. Surveys suggest today in PM Kisan [Yojana], more than 25 per cent of beneficiaries are women. This number will keep increasing,” he added.
This is also leading to more credit and other benefits getting accrued to women farmers.
“But ownership may not be enough, because ultimately the decision-maker in entrepren-



WOMEN EMPOWERMENT. Devesh Chaturvedi said in the next five years, India will have six crore women in villages earning more than a lakh every year PHOTOS BY BUDY GHOSE



neurship has to be women. They need to have more and more say. That is also happening,” said Chaturvedi.
DRONE DIDI
The Secretary stressed on the role of technological integration and highlighted the ‘Drone Didi’ programme.
Under the programme, more than 1,000

drones have already been distributed to SHG-trained women, with plans for further expansion, he said.
The rise of ‘Krishi Sakhis’ (70,000 trained in natural farming) and ‘Pashu Sakhis’ is turning women into primary drivers of sustainable agriculture and animal health.
EXPANDING FPO MANDATE
The Secretary emphasised that the mandate for farmer producer organisations (FPOs) has been expanded to include those who do not own land but do agriculture work, ensuring more rural women gain voice as shareholders and decision-makers.
The Secretary pointed out that it was primarily women who were driving the mission on natural farming.
“To balance more productivity and income with safe food and safe soil, it is the women folk who play a major role. So, it is through women we are running the mission of natural farming,” he said.

Need to shift to market-determined prices from MSP: Nabard Chairman

Prabhudatta Mishra
New Delhi

Outlining the three imperatives of agricultural development — economic, climate and social — Nabard Chairman KV Shaji said on Friday that the minimum support price (MSP) system can be replaced if some structural shifts are implemented. He suggested market-determined prices as an alternative, provided risks to farmers are covered.
Addressing the Agri & Commodity Summit 2026 in New Delhi, Shaji said: “Right now, the problem is that the minimum support price, which is government-determined, is a drain on the exchequer. So, we need to graduate from that into market-driven support prices.”
Explaining further, Shaji said commodity derivatives can help in this endeavour. “We are working with NCDEX to develop such derivatives. We are now doing a pilot programme where farmer producer organisations (FPOs) are encouraged to enter into put options for selling their produce so that wherever prices move, they can keep the upside,” he said.

PUT OPTION
A put option is a derivative contract for which farmers need to pay a small fee to lock in the price; whatever upside there is, they can retain. If there is a downside, only the fee they have paid is the loss to the farmer, he added.
Highlighting that Nabard has a major project underway — the graduation of rural income projects involving the ultra poor — he said the government wants to find permanent solutions to uplift them by integrating them into mobile financial systems. In the context of value chain fixing, there is a need to close several gaps, he said, adding that the commodity market gap is one of them.

BETTER FACILITIES
He also noted that Nabard is working with cooperatives on warehouse improvement, enhancing facilities as part of the



KV Shaji, Chairman, Nabard, delivering the special address at the summit

Commenting on agricultural credit, the Nabard chief said the govt’s AgriStack initiative will help in linking farmers to various activities

world’s largest grain storage structure programme announced by the Prime Minister.
In partnership with the Department of Cooperation, Nabard is building around 500 cooperative storage structures, which will be linked to platforms.
“We are working with NCDEX on how to link these storage structures to the derivative market so that there are proper physical structures to help farmers realise better income,” he said.
In that context, MSPs can be replaced with market-determined prices, he said, adding that some sort of formalisation structure needs to be in place.

STRUCTURAL SHIFT
He identified five important structural shifts that should happen, one of which is the formal recognition of women as farmers. “For that, ownership of land is very crucial. The government is encouraging it, for which several initiatives have been taken so that women should own farms. Even if they are not earn-

ing, their activities can be appropriately mapped through digital means and interactive processes,” he said.
Commenting on agricultural credit, he said the government’s AgriStack initiative will help in linking farmers to various activities. However, he also highlighted that Nabard has been making efforts to create awareness among cooperative and regional rural banks to disburse credit to a larger number of women farmers.
Noting that almost 50 per cent of the rural workforce in the agricultural sector comprises women, he said due to historical reasons, women are not landowners and have been excluded from meaningful economic activity. Stressing that Nabard was supporting self-help groups (SHGs) which, when launched in the early 1990s, were basically informal institutions without any registration or legal identity, he said currently 17 crore rural households are covered under SHGs, of which almost 95 per cent are women.
Shaji also said that 1.45 crore SHGs are savings-linked, of which 83 lakh are credit-linked, with an outstanding bank credit of nearly ₹3 lakh crore.
Stressing that farmer producer organisations (FPOs) are rural enterprises, the Nabard Chairman said women FPOs, which are more close-knit, are building on the successes achieved through SHGs.



ENGROSSED. A cross-section of the audience in rapt attention at the summit

Investment demand to provide steady support for gold, say experts

Our Bureau
New Delhi

Even as gold prices remain beyond the reach of the common man, experts said the yellow metal is a good investment option with potential to move higher in the future. In the session, ‘Precious Metals: Beyond Aam Aadmi’s Reach’, experts concurred that they do not see any immediate relief in the volatility of gold prices unless global insecurities stabilise. But households should find a way to monetise the gold they hold, especially against the background of rising wealth driven by higher gold prices.
According to research by Morgan Stanley, Indian households hold about 34,600 tonnes of gold and a large chunk of it is in rural India. Gold has had a very sharp run over the last couple of years.

businessline.
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In one year alone, it was up by 84 per cent. In 1964, 10 g of 24 karat gold was priced at ₹63. But now, 10 g of 24 karat gold will cost ₹1,65,000. And 22 karat gold is available at about ₹145,000. Likewise, 1 g of gold costs between ₹14,000 and ₹15,000.
“Gold is not a cash flow-generating asset to start with. The recent rally is driven by the changing economic world order. Central banks have played a key role in ramping up their gold reserves, led by the wave of de-dollarisation. I don’t see that changing anytime soon,” said Tarun Kanwar, Director, Navrattan Jewellers, Delhi, while replying to the question on whether the current rally in gold will continue.
This found an echo in the subsequent assertions of two others speakers — Kavita Chacko, Research Head, India, World Gold Council, and Jateen Trivedi, Vice-President, Commodity and Currency Research, LKP Securities. However, Trivedi sees an opportunity in the disruptive gold market.
“The volatility is definitely going to be there, but that volatility will give us an opportunity to enter because gold is not in a one-way street,” he remarked.
With moderator Lokeshwarri

SK, Data Editor, *businessline*, the three speakers navigated a complex array of issues confronting the precious metal industry, as well as the struggle arising from market dynamics. The rural-urban divide on consumption pattern and youngsters’ liking for lightweight, ready-to-wear jewellery were part of the threadbare discussion.
GOLD CONSUMPTION
Answering a question on whether gold consumption has come down in India due to price increase, the experts noted that though the volume has taken a hit, the value has been compensated largely due to the increase in gold price.
But the fact that precious metals are finding different investment avenues — sovereign gold bonds (SGBs) for interest and safety, gold ETFs/funds for liquidity, digital gold for convenience and jewellery savings schemes for physical acquisition — is increasing the investment demand for gold, thereby keeping demand steady.
“So what is interesting is that gold demand has been very resilient. That said, there is a slight shift in the product mix. Jewellery demand in terms of volume has



(from left) Lokeshwarri SK, Data Editor, *businessline*; Kavita Chacko, Research Head, India, World Gold Council; Jateen N Trivedi, V-P, Commodity and Currency Research, LKP Securities; and Tarun Kanwar, Director, Navrattan Jewellers, Delhi

come down. And at the same time, investment demand in physical or gold-backed financial products has seen an increase,” said Chacko.
“In 2025, jewellery demand for India was 420 tonnes. It was a 12 per cent increase in value. Investment demand for bars and coins was 280 tonnes, which was a 17

per cent increase year-on-year. Demand for ETFs was around 27 tonnes last year.”
Kanwar had an interesting observation about recycled gold finding its way into the market.
“It’s actually a good thing because it brings down the burden on our imports a little lower. Our government has been trying to

monetise the gold that households have been sitting on and bring it back into circulation. Recycling is almost 30 per cent to 40 per cent of our total sales,” the jeweller pointed out.
Lakhpati Didi from Tripura, Aruna Debbarma, who was invited as a guest for another session, candidly stated that possessing

gold was still a dream for women of her background. The suggestion from the expert to conclude was that people can think of having 15 per cent to 20 per cent gold investment in their overall portfolio, given that increased price of gold has correspondingly led to rise in the wealth of precious metal holders as well.

‘With 80% of women denied loans, access to funding need of the hour’



INCLUSION PUSH. (from left) Subramani Ra Mancombu, Consulting Editor, *businessline*; Anupam Gupta, CBO, Kissandhan; Ravi Kumar, Lead-Smallholder farming, South Asia, Bayer AG; and Ajay Kumar Jha, Deputy General Manager, Product Development and Marketing, SBI, at the summit held in New Delhi BUJOY GHOSH

Our Bureau
New Delhi

Banks prefer women borrowers as their repayment rates are higher, and yet over 80 per cent of women farmers are denied loans compared to 43 per cent of men.

Is there a bias? How can women, who are often the backbone of the rural economy, get more funding?

This was the topic of a panel discussion, titled ‘Seeds of Funding’, at the *businessline* Agri & Commodity Summit 2026, in which Anupam Gupta, CBO, Kissandhan; Ravi Kumar, Lead-smallholder farming, South Asia, Bayer AG; and Ajay Kumar Jha, Deputy General Manager, Product Development and Marketing, SBI, discussed the barriers to funding and how these can be overcome.

The discussion was moderated by Subramani Ra Man-

combu, Consulting Editor, *businessline*. According to Ravi Kumar, rather than bias, structural issues prevent women from getting loans.

STRUCTURAL ISSUE

“There is a lack of documentation, and women are rarely able to furnish collateral as they do not have land ownership. Also, financial literacy is a challenge,” he said. He also said the small size of loans, too, poses a challenge to lending organisations.

SBI’s Jha said the bank always rated women borrowers very highly, but the problem in giving loans to them was the lack of ownership of land. If women get into the full value chain of agriculture, from sowing to setting up processing units, it is easier for SBI to give loans as they do not need to show land ownership, he said.

According to Anupam Gupta, Kissandhan had worked around the problem of lack of

land ownership by routing loans through farmer producer organisations (FPOs). “We do funding through FPOs, and have impacted the lives of 7 lakh farmers. There are more than 50,000 ladies in FPOs, and many FPOs have only women members,” he said.

He pointed out that Kissandhan had a presence in Rajasthan, Madhya Pradesh, Odisha and Maharashtra.

Ravi Kumar pointed out that when women farmers fail to get financial help from NBFCs and banks, they resort to borrowing from informal lenders at a much higher rate of interest. “They don’t get right inputs from informal lenders and their income gets impacted as their cost of cultivation becomes higher,” he said.

WAY FORWARD

The panel unanimously urged policy changes, such as simplifying KCC, showing leniency in collaterals, and designing spe-

cific products keeping in mind the requirements and constraints of women borrowers.

Gupta advocated creating financial and digital literacy and empowering women farmers with a mobile phone.

“Societal recognition needs to be given,” stressed Ravi Kumar. “Women should not be seen as labourers, but seen as asset owners and should be given digital literacy,” he said.

Jha pointed out that value addition was crucial for women farmers, and there were many initiatives through which they could be beneficiaries.

“Fifteen per cent of our agri portfolio is accessed through self-help groups,” he said, adding that one of the highest amounts it had disbursed without collateral was ₹100 crore.

The success stories of women farmers must be celebrated more so that more women are inspired, the panel concluded.

‘Milk consumption outpaces production’

DAIRY EFFICIENCY. Heritage Foods Executive Director calls for higher per-animal yield and stronger veterinary infrastructure

Rohit Vaid
New Delhi

Even though milk production in India is growing annually, the country’s consumption is rising, potentially creating supply pressures if productivity improvements do not keep up, Brahmani Nara, Executive Director of Heritage Foods, said at the *businessline* Agri & Commodity Summit 2026.

Speaking at a fireside chat session with Raghuvir Srinivasan, Editor, *businessline*, she said India remains self-sufficient in milk, but demand growth in certain segments is outpacing productivity gains.

“Milk production is growing at around 4 per cent. However, consumption is growing at a faster pace,” Brahmani said, adding that without structural interventions, supply-demand mismatches could emerge.

YIELD CHALLENGE

According to Brahmani, per animal productivity in India remains significantly lower than in the United States and Europe.

She said the focus must be on improving yield per animal rather than increasing herd size.

Besides, Brahmani identified breed improvement through artificial insemination, better mineral supplementation, improved cattle feed quality, and expansion of veterinary infrastructure as priority areas.

She also referred to the government’s emphasis on livestock development and scaling up the number of veterinarians, stating that such measures are aligned with the sec-



VET STRENGTHENING. Brahmani Nara, ED, Heritage Foods, at a fireside chat with Raghuvir Srinivasan, Editor, *businessline* BUJOY GHOSH

tor’s requirements.

VALUE-ADDED FOCUS

Apart from productivity, Brahmani outlined the company’s positioning in value-added dairy segments.

Heritage Foods, she said, sees itself as a value-added dairy player and not only a liquid milk supplier.

The company was an early entrant in packaged curd and continues to expand in categories such as paneer, ghee, butter, cheese and ice cream.

PROCUREMENT, PAYMENTS

She pointed out that milk is procured from over 3,00,000 farmers, nearly 70 per cent of whom are women.

Payments, Brahmani said are transferred directly into farmers’

bank accounts every 10-15 days through a digitised system.

Additionally, she said the company conducts more than 25 quality tests per batch and aims to move milk from farm to shelf within 24-36 hours wherever feasible.

Brahmani said that procurement operations are digitised, quality testing is automated, and batch-level traceability has been introduced through Quick Response (QR) codes on packaging.

The company also uses analytics and artificial intelligence for demand forecasting and supply chain management.

In addition, Brahmani said that dairy remains a significant contributor to agricultural output and provides a steady income stream for rural households.

Credit and care hold the key to women’s role in agriculture

Our Bureau
New Delhi

Even as women are considered among the key architects of India’s farm economy, their contribution to the sector has not been effectively mapped, which is also reflected in the lack of opportunities for them in the agriculture space.

For these silent architects of India’s rural economy, a major role reversal is required, which should not only recognise their contribution in the field, but also the importance of household work. Better avenues to raise capital and more focussed government policies are other measures that can further enhance their contribution to the farm economy.

During the panel discussion, ‘Women: Silent architects of the rural economy’, at the *businessline*’s Agri & Commodity Summit 2026, the consensus was on the need to recognise the role of women in household work.

CARE ECONOMY

Sarban Bose, CoE Lead, Gender Equality at Pradhan, emphasised that the significance of the care economy is not highlighted as

much as it should be. Sustaining a household is a critical aspect of a flourishing economy.

“Women in rural India, in the age group of 18-30 years, work in the house and in the fields. But they do not have much say in decision making. Income is not coming into their account. We do not talk enough about the care economy. The government has to invest in the care economy. For instance, crèches should be set up at the panchayat level. Safety of young girls is important,” she added.

Kalyani Singh, a rural entrepreneur at the Better Life Farming Alliance, stressed that encouraging a stronger role for women in the farm sector has to start with them having more say in rural finance. They should be able to access affordable finance.

“They do not have access to many avenues for raising finance as they usually do not have land assets in their name. So, there should be a correct assessment of their work, both household work and that in the field. They should be paid according to this work,” she added.

SHARE & RECOGNITION

Chhavi Rajawat, former sarpanch of Soda village, Rajasthan, sup-



(from left) Shishir Sinha, Associate Editor, *businessline*; Sarban Bose, CoE Lead, Gender Equality, PRADAN; Chhavi Rajawat, former Sarpanch, Soda village, Rajasthan; Sanjiv Kanwar, MD, Yara South Asia and Country Head, Yara India; and Kalyani Singh, Entrepreneur, Better Life Farming Alliance, at a session on ‘Silent Architects of the Rural Economy’ at the *businessline* Agri & Commodity Summit 2026 BUJOY GHOSH

ported Sarban Bose and Kalyani’s stress on recognising the role of the care economy in the country’s economy and, more importantly, the farm sector.

“Women do not get the right value for their work. So, there is a need to push back. How do we bring about change? Will men pass on land or asset ownership to

women? Can we have joint ownership of land assets? These are important questions that have to be addressed. The government is shifting its focus, which is commendable. But more needs to be done,” she added.

Recognition and the right share in farm wages are key, emphasised Sanjiv Kanwar, MD, Yara

South Asia, and Country Head of Yara India.

“We have around 10 million women farmers in India, and almost 50-70 per cent don’t have land titles in their name, which means if you do not have a land title, then there is no collateral, and they cannot get access to cheap credit. So, credit access

hinders growth,” he pointed out.

Bose pointed out that women-led Farmer Producer Organisations (FPOs) do not get easy access to credit as they do not have land in their name.

CREDIT FOR FPOs

The FPO credit system needs to be strengthened with women en-

trepreneurs in mind. Singh agreed, adding that women-led FPOs should be trained in farm mechanisation so they can transfer these skills to other women in their areas.

She also said such FPOs need affordable and easy loans to purchase large machines, which can then be rented out to women farmers at low rates.

Kanwar made a few very pertinent observations about the lack of women’s leadership in the farm economy.

“In agricultural universities, around 40-50 per cent of students are women, and they are delivering better grades compared to male students. However, only 6-8 per cent of women who graduated in agriculture are in senior corporate roles,” he added.

Another point emphasised by Kanwar is that civil society in the farm sector is largely male-dominated. During the panel discussion, Bose said there is little data available on various aspects of the farm economy.

“We need to know how much income has increased for women and men. Data on infrastructure in rural India, such as the number of crèches in panchayats or how many panchayats have 100 per cent sanitation,” she added.

AT A GLANCE



ALL FARMERS. (from left) Swati-Uttarakhand, Shivani Singh-Bihar, and a grower from Gurugram, raise queries



MEANINGFUL INSIGHT. A section of the audience at the summit

QUICKLY.

2026 Isuzu V-Cross
launched in India

Isuzu has launched the 2026 V-Cross in India with prices starting at ₹25.50 lakh (ex-showroom). The update brings minor



design changes, feature additions and a revised variant lineup. The entry-level Z 4x2 AT has been discontinued, and all remaining variants have seen price increases, taking the range up to ₹30 lakh. Exterior updates include new dual-tone 18-inch alloy wheels, body-coloured fog lamp surrounds and skid plate, black grille accents and updated LED indicators on the ORVMs. Inside, the V-Cross now gets a 10.3-inch floating touchscreen, wireless Apple CarPlay and Android Auto, a 360-degree camera and leatherette trim inserts. The pickup continues with the 1.9-litre diesel engine producing 161 bhp and 36.7 kg-m, paired with manual and automatic options, with 4x4 now standard.

Volkswagen Tayron R-Line
available at ₹46.99 lakh

The Volkswagen Tayron R-Line is the brand's new flagship SUV. It is priced ₹1.26 lakh higher than the Tiguan R-Line. Measuring 4.7



m in length with a 2789 mm wheelbase, the Tayron R-Line features 19 inch alloy wheels, illuminated Volkswagen logos and 'R' badges. It also gets LED headlamps and connected tail-lamps, with seven colour options available. Inside, the SUV offers three-row seating with a sliding second row, a 15-inch touchscreen, 10.25-inch digital instrument cluster and heads-up display. Features include a panoramic sunroof and three-zone climate control. Power comes from a 2.0-litre TSI petrol engine producing 201 bhp and 32.6 kg-m, paired with a 7-speed dual-clutch transmission.

Royal Enfield offers
E20 conversion kits

Royal Enfield has introduced E20 fuel conversion kits for older BS3 and BS4 versions of the Classic 350, Bullet 350 and



Thunderbird 350. The kits are designed to help these motorcycles run reliably on petrol blended with up to 20 per cent ethanol,

which has been introduced across India. The upgrade replaces key fuel system components, including fuel lines, seals and gaskets, with ethanol-resistant parts to prevent premature wear, leaks or blockages. The retrofit is primarily aimed at unit-construction engine models that are equipped with carburettors. Royal Enfield advises installation at authorised service centres. The kit for BS4 models is priced around ₹1,700, while BS3 versions may cost more depending on additional carburettor-related upgrades and parts availability.

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Manaal Mahatme

There's something tricky about building a middleweight tourer. Get it wrong, and experienced riders will call it dull. Make it too aggressive, and newcomers upgrading from smaller machines will feel like they've accidentally adopted a wild horse. That's why the 2026 Ducati Multistrada V2 matters.

I rode it everywhere you're supposed to test a machine like this — the urban jungle, wide highways, tight twisties, broken backroads and even mild trails. Because a middleweight ADV tourer has one job — to do everything without making you feel like you've bitten off more than you can chew.

At the heart of the new V2 S sits Ducati's 890cc 90-degree V2, and it behaves exactly how you'd expect something wearing that badge to behave — completely unhinged in the best possible way. It sprints to the red line with enthusiasm, deploying all 113 bhp like it's late for something important. Ducati has moved away from desmodromic valves here, adopting chain-driven cams, finger followers and spring valves, along with variable valve timing. The result feels distinctly different from the older 937cc Testastretta engine — smoother in delivery, but no less ferocious when provoked.

And the soundtrack? Even with the stock exhaust, every upshift comes with a cheeky pop and every throttle roll-off is followed by naughty crackles. So, slowing down at signals is almost like announcing your grand entry to oth-

Red Reason

SPORTY PRECISION. The Ducati Multistrada V2 S is a bike that excites without overwhelming ambition



TRENDSETTER. Ducati Multistrada V2 S, an exhilarating, adaptable middleweight tourer that thrills without overpowering KAIZAD ADIL, DARUKHANAWALA

ers. Yet here's the clever bit — you can tame it. Power modes, engine brake control, ABS, traction control, wheelie control — it's all adjustable. You can transform this excitable Italian into something remarkably civilised with a few clicks. It's like giving a hyperactive dog obedience training; the energy is still there, but now it sits or pounces on command.

FINE BALANCE

Visually, the Multi looks substantial, almost intimidating. But the moment you swing a leg over it, that perception dissolves. The 19

litre tank is shaped perfectly for knee grip, the handlebar reach is natural, and while the seat can be set at 830 mm, the taller 850 mm position actually felt more comfortable. Even then, flat-footing wasn't an issue.

At 199 kg (kerb weight without fuel), it weighs as much as some single-cylinder ADVs built much closer to home. That lightness translates into easy low-speed handling. Crawling through traffic doesn't feel like balancing on a tightrope. Out on the highway, though, the Ducati DNA shines through. It devours dis-

tances effortlessly. Cruising at high speeds feels so relaxed that you'd better keep an eye on the speedometer — unless you enjoy funding the local traffic department. The Pirelli Scorpion Trail II tyres offer excellent grip on tarmac, encouraging you to lean further than you initially planned.

The S variant's Showa electronically adjustable suspension deserves applause. Switching between 'hard', 'medium', 'soft' and 'softest' is straightforward, and 'Dynamic' mode continuously adapts damping to the road. It genuinely changes the bike's

character. Feeling aggressive? Firm it up. Riding home after a long day? Soften it. There's also a practical party trick — a button that drops preload completely, lowering the seat height to help shorter riders or pillions mount and dismount. It's thoughtful engineering, not gimmickry.

Then there's the Mumbai test — 40-degree afternoons and gridlocked traffic. The engine temperature climbed to 112°C, but most of the heat was directed away from me. Yes, the tank and seat area warmed up in prolonged traffic, but the moment the road

cleared and the throttle opened, airflow sorted things out quickly. For a big V-twin in tropical conditions, that's commendable.

The electronics package is extensive enough to make some flagship machines nervous, yet it never feels overwhelming. Each riding mode comes with well-judged default settings and you can gradually explore deeper customisation as your confidence grows. It meets you where you are — whether you're stepping up from a smaller bike or downsizing from something larger and more demanding.

At ₹21 lakh (ex-showroom), the Multistrada V2 S isn't cheap. But you're paying for explosive performance, a sophisticated monocoque frame, semi-active suspension, a comprehensive electronics suite and that unmistakable Ducati character. More importantly, the Italian marque seems to have understood the brief. A middleweight tourer must thrill seasoned riders while remaining approachable for the ambitious ones climbing the ladder. And the Multistrada V2 does that effortlessly.

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X Factor

HEAD TURNER. More power, more capability and the same driver-first DNA — the X3 turns the dial up



SWAPNIL DHAWALE

Kurt Morris

The BMW X3 xDrive30 M Sport Pro may have one of the longest names seen on any car sold in the country, but it also happens to be an important car in BMW India's lineup right now. Sitting at the heart of the mid-size luxury SUV segment, the X3 has become one of BMW's best sales performers. If you look at BMW India's 2025 numbers, it's clear the brand has closed the gap with its German rivals and products such as the X3 have played a vital role in that rise. The first thing you notice about the new X3 is that it no longer plays it safe.

'Bold' is the word that best describes this design. Right up front, the illuminated kidney grille dominates the face and while it may still divide opinion, there's no denying the drama it adds, especially at night. Unlock the car in a dimly lit parking lot, and the soft glow from the grille instantly announces its presence. It is theatrical and unmistakably BMW. Beyond the grille, there's a lot to admire. The LED headlamps are sharp and modern, the bumper sculpting is aggressive without being messy, and the bonnet features strong creases that give the X3 a muscular, purposeful look. Move to the side, and you'll still recognise the familiar X3 silhouette, but the surfacing is tighter and more defined. At the rear, sharp lines across the tailgate and bumper give the SUV a planted, athletic stance. This is an X3 that looks like it means business.

For the drive, we were handed the keys and sent off on an off-road route that included dry riverbeds, steep inclines, deep ruts and articulation tests. These are trails usually tackled in proper body-on-frame 4x4 SUVs, so scepticism was natural. After all, this is a luxury SUV. However, from the moment we set

off, the X3 felt comfortable tackling terrain that most owners will never even consider. Wheelspin was minimal, articulation was impressive and even when one wheel was in the air, the xDrive system redistributed torque to the wheels with traction. Steep inclines were dispatched with ease and the extra torque on tap made a noticeable difference. BMW clearly has a lot of confidence in the X3's capability, and rightly so.

Under the hood is BMW's updated 2.0-litre four-cylinder petrol engine, internally known as the B48. In this iteration, it benefits from the mild-hybrid assistance and produces 255 bhp along with a strong 40.78 kg-m. On the road, those numbers translate to a noticeably stronger and more responsive driving experience. Acceleration is brisk, overtakes are effortless and the engine feels eager across the rev range. Put your foot down from a standstill or a rolling speed and you can genuinely feel the performance pushing you back into the seat.

BMW claims 0-100 kph in 6.3 seconds, and it feels every bit as quick. Select Sport mode and the difference is immediate — sharper throttle response, more urgency from the drivetrain and a tighter overall feel. Yet, despite the added performance, refinement remains excellent. The engine stays smooth and quiet, with very little noise making its way into the cabin.

Power is sent to all four wheels via an 8-speed automatic gearbox that continues to be one of the best in the business. Shifts are smooth, quick and intuitive. There's also a boost mode where the gearbox holds onto gears longer and a visual boost indicator flashes on the instrument cluster, delivering that extra burst of performance when you need it.

BMW's xDrive all-wheel-drive system deserves special mention. During our off-road drive, it proved just how intelligent and effective it



BOLD CHOICE. Experience the X3's strengths, driving dynamics, refinement and everyday usability — a standout in luxury mid-size SUVs SWAPNIL DHAWALE

is. Power is constantly shuffled between wheels depending on grip levels; when one wheel loses contact with the ground, torque is instantly sent to the wheels that can use it best. And all this happens while you're seated in a cabin that feels anything but rugged.

STRONG SUITS

BMW's interiors have taken a noticeable step forward, and the X3 benefits greatly from that evolution. The first thing you notice when you settle into the driver's seat is just how comfortable it is. The seats are broader, more supportive and hold you firmly in place,

thanks to larger side bolsters. BMW made a point of highlighting that these seats are wider than those in the regular X3, and it shows. They strike an excellent balance between comfort and sportiness, supportive during spirited driving, yet relaxed enough for long journeys. Material quality is high throughout the cabin and everything feels solidly put together.

Ride and handling have always been the X3's strongest suits and this new iteration builds on that reputation. Part of the credit goes to the wheel and tyre setup. The X3 rides on 20-inch M light alloy wheels, with an asymmetric tyre

setup — 255/45 R20 at the front and wider 285/40 R20 tyres at the rear. This setup pays dividends. The X3 feels solidly planted through corners, with excellent grip and stability. Despite being an SUV, it doesn't feel tall or unwieldy when you push it through twisty roads. Turn-in is sharp, body control is impressive and the chassis feels balanced and confidence-inspiring.

Ride comfort, surprisingly, is also very good. The suspension absorbs bumps and broken surfaces well, even though deeper potholes can send a jolt through the cabin. Still, for a car with this level of handling prowess, the ride quality is commendable. Even during extended off-road driving, the cabin remained composed and the supportive seats ensured you weren't thrown around as the terrain got rough.

The BMW X3 comes well-equipped, ticking most of the boxes you'd expect in this segment. The infotainment screen is crisp and vibrant, as is the digital instrument cluster. Both displays are easy to read and respond quickly to inputs. That said, BMW's UI/UX could use a bit of refinement. Some of the menu layouts and icons feel slightly dated, and don't quite match the modern high-tech feel of the rest of the cabin. It's not a deal-breaker, but it stands out in an otherwise polished package.

The BMW X3 xDrive30 M Sport Pro represents a meaningful evolution of an already successful formula. It builds on the X3's strengths, driving dynamics, refinement and everyday usability, while adding more performance and capability into the mix. At the end of the day, if you're buying a luxury German SUV, you expect a certain level of performance and this X3 delivers exactly that. Not over the top, not excessive, but accessible, usable and immensely satisfying.

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REIT moves

Easier bank finance with guardrails, way forward

The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) has done well to liberalise lending to Real Estate Investment Trusts (REITs). Now, banks can lend to REITs directly, instead of going through special purpose vehicles. With bank lending rates moving lower, REITs can access more funds at lower cost to scale their operations. Banks too can grow their loan books through this segment.

The five listed REITs hold assets worth ₹2.5 lakh crore and enjoy market capitalisation of ₹1.72 lakh crore. Yet the Indian REITs industry has not achieved the scale seen in other countries. It forms a small part of the over \$2.2 trillion global REITs market. REITs can play an important intermediation role in channelising household savings into the real estate market. The stock market regulator has been making a series of changes in this segment in the recent past to improve investor demand and awareness. These include classifying REITs as equity instruments to allow mutual funds to invest in them, allowing REITs to be included in equity indices and expanding the scope of strategic investors in these instruments. The RBI is acting in concert. But given the cyclicality in real estate prices, banks face higher credit risk. To this end, the RBI has introduced some guardrails to ensure that banks do not increase their stressed assets.

Under these norms, total bank credit taken by a REIT and its SPVs is being capped at 49 per cent of its assets. REITs will be encouraged to explore other sources of funding such as the bond market. The RBI has disallowed bullet and balloon repayment models here, perhaps in view of risk posed by cyclical swings. Under such arrangements, the initial instalments are small, with a large lumpsum falling towards the end of the loan tenure. Restricting bank lending to publicly listed REITs is also a good idea since listed entities face greater scrutiny and are more transparent in their operations. Other stipulations include: First, REITs availing of credit should be well established, with three years of operations and distributable cash flows in the two preceding financial years; second, special purpose vehicles should not be in financial distress or under regulatory action for any misconduct; third, banks should finance finalised projects, and not refinance existing loans; and finally, loans should be fully secured through mortgage of assets in REIT.

The central bank can however review the rule that lending to REITs can be up to 10 per cent of a bank’s eligible capital base. This ceiling appears too high given the size of the REIT segment in the economy. The RBI will also have to be extra vigilant in the initial years to monitor the end use of funds lent to REITs. The caution should be viewed against a history of defalcation in this sector by large developers. The Real Estate (Regulation and Development) Act, 2016 has worked to an extent in tightening processes. In sum, the sector should be liberalised, but with an element of circumspection given the intrinsic risks.

OTHER VOICES.



A Gaza divided cannot stand
For a territory at the heart of decades-long occupation, the Gaza Strip is small. At only 365 square kilometres, the enclave represents just 1.3 per cent of the Mandatory Palestine that existed between 1920 and 1948. Yet Gaza is being further partitioned between occupying Israeli forces and Hamas militants. According to Israeli NGO Gisha the army's so-called Yellow Line — beyond which Palestinians are forbidden from travelling — leaves well over 50 per cent of Gaza in Israeli hands. This fact has not gone unnoticed by those tasked with ending the conflict. Nickolay Mladenov, high representative for Gaza on the US-led Board of Peace, said there were currently “two Gazas”. “We have one part of Gaza, which is under Hamas control, where only humanitarian aid and some commercial goods are allowed to go in, and we have another part of Gaza, which is controlled by the Israeli army,” he explained. (DUBAI, FEBRUARY 25)

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL.
EUROPE

AI and the data centre backlash
President Trump sought to mollify a growing public backlash against AI data centres Tuesday by proposing to require that companies build their own power plants. It’s a good idea that could help accelerate innovation and ease electric rates, though it will require AI companies to sacrifice their green posturing. “Many Americans are also concerned that energy demand from AI data centres could unfairly drive up their electric utility bills,” Mr. Trump said. “We’re telling the major tech companies that they have the obligation to provide for their own power needs.” This may soon become a political and business necessity. (NEW YORK, FEBRUARY 26)

Why the concern over capital flows

UNDER PRESSURE. With developed markets too becoming a draw for investors, the outlook on the currency looks slightly uncertain



MADAN SABNAVIS

The RBI’s new regulation on ECBs (external commercial borrowings) can be read along with the message given in the Economic Survey on the rupee being under pressure in the year. This is notwithstanding an otherwise remarkable performance of the economy. The current account deficit is very much in control even though the exporters have faced challenging times. It is the capital account that has been transformed, putting pressure on the currency. The measures announced by the RBI on the amount and tenure of borrowing will surely help companies raise more money in this market and support the capital account.

Historically the capital account was kept steady by FPI and FDI which have become more fragile. While often it is argued that we need to be more open to such investment, polices have been comprehensive; and it does look like that nothing substantive can really be done. FDI can flow into almost all sectors with limits being increased over time. The challenge is to have investors interested in the India story. It is the pull factor rather than push which matters here.

THE PULL FACTORS
There are two main issues here. The first is that there needs to be a growing global corpus of investible funds to be deployed in overseas markets. With quantitative easing of central banks giving way to tightening, there is less easy money available. The other factor is that the avenues for investment have widened over time. What was earlier ‘mainly emerging markets’ has now broadened to cover developed countries too which are working hard to push up growth. Therefore, European countries and the US are also active destinations for FDI. It will always be a challenge to get a higher slice of funds at this end.

Data on FDI show some interesting trends. The first is that gross FDI has been high in the last five years ending FY25 and averaged \$78 billion per annum which is impressive. However, the repatriation of equity has been rising quite prodigiously from \$27 billion in FY21 to \$51 billion in FY25. This has lowered the net inflows substantially. Clearly, companies are using these funds to pay dividend to their investors or deploying the same elsewhere. Second, the net FDI by Indian companies overseas has increased from around \$11 billion in FY21 to \$27 billion in FY25, which is often interpreted as a phenomenon of internationalisation of Indian firms. This is what has brought the net FDI number to less than \$10 billion, which is what affects the capital account in the balance of payments. Interestingly, during the first eight months of the current year, net FDI was just \$5.6 billion with gross FDI flows being \$27.7 billion and net FDI outflows \$22.1 billion.

THE FPI PICTURE
The picture on FPI is also interesting. There was a time when it was assumed that there could be \$30-40 billion flowing in every year with the inclusion of Indian bonds in the global indices providing a booster. However, this has not played out all the time. In FY24 \$41 billion came in after two years of negative flows. Covid was a good time for FPI which was high at \$36 billion. In FY25 net inflows were just \$1.6 billion and in FY26 a negative \$7.5 billion for the first 10 months of the year. Now, equity flows have tended to be negative for two reasons. The first is that Indian stocks are seemingly overvalued. While this argument is debatable, the high P-E ratios in some sectors have buttressed this argument

Equity flows have tended to be negative as Indian stocks are seemingly overvalued. While this argument is debatable, the high P-E ratios in some sectors have buttressed this argument



VOLATILE. Foreign portfolio investments were always considered to be ‘hot money flows’ given their nature GETTY IMAGES

butressed this argument that the upside remains limited unless earnings grow at sharp rates, which is not happening. Growth in earnings (denoted by net profits) has been quite subdued post Covid which probably does not justify high valuations in some sectors where the P-E ratio was in range of 30-40 like say FMCG, consumer durables, healthcare, realty, etc. The other is that the stocks in developed countries, including the US, UK, Japan, France and Germany, are doing very well making other markets attractive. Hence portfolio reallocation has been favouring other markets where the P-E ratios are relatively lower, at less than 15, thus promising a better upside. There is hence a lot of ambiguity when it comes to the capital account; the direction of net inflows would be hard to conjecture. These are decisions taken by overseas players, and policy reforms within the country have only a limited bearing on these outcomes. FDI was assumed to increase exponentially and numbers of \$100 billion on an annual basis were taken for as granted. However, investors have been taking back their profits which has affected the net inflows. Further, Indian companies are looking to diversify their businesses

outside the country which has made FDI fragile. FPIs were always considered to be ‘hot money flows’ given their nature. While this has not quite affected the stock market significantly as domestic institutional investors like mutual funds have been more than active in this market given the growing retail interest, the currency market has been under pressure. All this makes the capital account uncertain, given their volatile nature. New emerging geographies will offer scope for foreign direct investment while stock markets across the globe will provide opportunity for portfolio investors. This will be the new normal. Hence, it will be important to keep the current account balance under control; and the big hope for us is the IT sector that has potential to counter the deficit on the trade account. The focus on domestic production will help to an extent to lower demand for imports. However, all the FTAs signed would mean extending the perimeter for imports as our exports make deeper inroads into other countries. This means that a stable path for the rupee cannot be taken as a given.

The writer is Chief Economist, Bank of Baroda. Views are personal

Bridging funding gaps for sustainable farming

Globally, adaptation funding is falling short. India must strengthen its domestic sources, especially from the private sector

**A Amarendra Reddy
Tulsi Lingareddy**

India needs to prioritise financing for resilience in agricultural food production system, not only to ensure country’s future food security but also to protect the livelihoods of predominant small farmers. With growing number of recurring extreme weather events, India ranked as the ninth most affected country from climate change as per the Climate Risk Index 2026 published by Germanwatch in November 2025. Broadly speaking, it is important to note the growing gap between the required and actual finance for adaptation from international public finance flows. According to the latest Adaptation Gap Report 2025 by UNEP, the requirement of adaptation finance by developing countries like India is estimated at \$310-365 billion annually by 2035, 12-14 times higher than the actual flow of funds at \$26 billion per year. Under such a scenario, India needs to strengthen the domestic climate finance ecosystem for for ensuring future food security and livelihoods of farmers. Globally, adaptation fund mobilisation has slowed significantly, becoming a cause for concern. However,

it is heartening that there were considerable efforts during COP30 in Belem, Brazil, particularly towards promoting adaptation in agriculture. The agri-food system receives only about 20 per cent of total adaptation funds against the requirement of about 54 per cent, according to the ‘Agrifood Systems in National Adaptation Plans — An analysis’ report, published by the Food and Agriculture Organization (FAO) and United Nations Development Programme (UNDP) in November 2025.

NEW PLATFORM
In view of this, India along with 13 other developing countries agreed at COP30 to launch a new country platform that can become an operational vehicle for NAP with the support of Green Climate Fund (GCF). The platform is being planned to serve as unified mechanism connecting domestic public finance, private investment, and international climate funds. In India, while there is no comprehensive estimate available on the status of domestic climate finance flows for adaptation in agriculture sector, a partially tracked estimate by the Climate Policy Initiative (CPI) puts it at around ₹265 billion, (\$3.6 billion) accounting for only about 24 per cent of total funds for adaptation, at ₹1,092 billion, in 2021-22. The estimate tracked on-farm



SHORT SUPPLY. Private investment

agricultural adaptation activities including agroforestry, crop insurance, efficient irrigation, research and capacity building, resilient cropping system and soil and water conservation. Nevertheless, financing adaptation of agriculture in India also stood substantially lower than the required amount of \$67 billion annually from 2015 to 2030. Some of the major reasons for the substantial gap in financing for adaptation in agriculture are dismal participation from private sector sources and limited flow of international public finances. Public sector sources of funds, primarily from Central and State government budgets, accounted for 98-99 per cent, while private funding, at about ₹2.7 billion, accounted for only about 1 per cent of total domestic finance for adaptation in agriculture. Poor participation from the private

sector is mainly due to inherent investment risks in agriculture, with increased frequency of extreme weather events, long gestation periods for returns, difficulties in defining clear business cases. Moreover, over 80 per cent of the end-users of technological innovations from such investments are smallholder farmers. Their small and fragmented landholdings limit the feasibility to achieve economies of scale, thereby discouraging large scale investments from the private sector. Under such a situation, public finances must continue to take precedence over private finances. The private sector must, however, be encouraged to invest with suitable financial strategies and instruments such as blended finance, public-private partnerships, schemes with minimal assured return, etc. Further, it is essential to build well-functioning, efficiently regulated and transparent domestic climate finance ecosystem for seamless flow of funds, creating comprehensive knowledge and data for climate risk assessment. Reddy is Joint Director, Policy Support Research, ICAR-National Institute of Biotic Stress Management, Raipur, and Lingareddy is Senior Economist, Sustainable Finance and Agriculture, Mumbai. Views are personal

✉ **LETTERS TO EDITOR** Send your letters by email to bleditor@thehindu.co.in or by post to ‘Letters to the Editor’, The Hindu Business Line, Kasturi Buildings, 859-860, Anna Salai, Chennai 600002.

Flyer-friendly rules
This refers to ‘New 48-hour free cancellation window introduced for air tickets’ (February 27). India’s aviation watchdog DGCA’s new rule will surely make air travel significantly more flyer-friendly. Passengers can now cancel or amend a booked ticket within 48 hours of purchase without any cancellation fee, provided the ticket is directly booked through the airline’s website. This new rule will address key issues like accidental bookings, sudden plan changes. Delayed refunds by the airlines has been a big complaint by the flyers and to address this a 14-day timeline has been set. All

those passengers who book well ahead of travel dates are expected to be biggest beneficiaries of this new rule. **Bal Govind** Noida **Review listing norms** With reference to ‘Securities Bill has a problematic Section’ (February 27), the overriding powers provided to the Centre by the new bill, diluting the critical listing norms in respect of public sector companies, should be reviewed and amended to establish governance transparency in the investment ecosystem. Though the ultimate vicarious liability for any

misdeeds of the investee companies lies with the government, being the core promoter and largest shareholder in majority of these undertakings, lack of uniformity of norms among public and private companies, may suppress the competitive spirit. **Sitaram Popuri** Bengaluru **Promote organic spices** Apropos ‘Supply shift reshape spices outlook’ (February 27). In general, spices are long term crops and highly susceptible to diseases that threaten yield as well as quality. Crops like ginger, turmeric and pepper get

quickly affected by changes in weather conditions, which compel farmers to use fungicides, etc., to minimise loss. It is time the Spices Board incentivised organic culture by offering weather based selection of spice crops and providing farmers on-field support. **Rajiv Magal** Halekere Village, Karnataka **Improving GDP accuracy** Apropos ‘New GDP series to use 600 item level data’ (February 27), the decision to use nearly 600 items instead of about 180 earlier is a welcome step. The full adoption of the double deflation method will improve the measurement of real growth. This method adjusts the prices of finished goods and raw materials separately across industries. As a result, the effect of inflation is measured more accurately. Earlier, a single price method was partly used. It mainly adjusted only output prices and could affect accuracy. Greater use of survey and GST data will better capture activity across sectors, including small businesses. More reliable GDP numbers will support better policy and investment decisions. **S Balasubramaniyan** Villupuram, TN





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(10-04-26) AASHTI - MAIN ROAD; PJC4GOL16262928, 16257515, 16445475. ADAMPUR - GRAIN MARKET; PLJ7GOL16379550. Adipur - Madansingh chowk; PES2GOL15416641, 15451149, 16169448, 16301102, 16447094, 16593008, 16650546. AGOOCHA; PYB2PFI16232905. AGRA - SHASTRIPURAM; PMW3GOL16430522. AHMEDABAD - GURUKUL; PKB9GOL11119896, 11150022, 11229937, 11341839, 15130299, 16207834, 16230619, 16269127, 16642346. Ahmedabad - Vastral; POB2GOL16186954, 16393771. AHMEDABAD - VIRAT NAGAR; PLB2GOL14965510, 16430282. AHMEDNAGAR - DELHIWATE; PGE7GOL15381613, 15381146, 16169532, 16451309. AHMEDNAGAR - SAVEDI ROAD; PER1GOL16247345, 16237851, 16295396, 16373287. AJJAMPURA - HOSADURGA ROAD; PKC4SGL15253971. AJMER - BEAWARE ROAD; P65HGOL15216931, 15375195, 16166879, 16183511, 16187677, 16299954, 16305933, 16300933, 16419896, 16476675, 16593544, 16720975. AJMER - INDIA MOTOR CIRCLE; PGU1GOL15038317, 15528123, 16194148, 16443559, 16524539, 16555723, 16556006, 16626590, 16677870, 16680015, 16680724, 16687366, 16700121, 16728465. AKLUJ - SHANKARRAO PLAZA; PCP6GOL16376758, 16624928. AKOLA - GANDHI ROAD; PJA8GOL16183845, 16376499, 16685858. AKOLA - KHADAN ROAD; PEP7GOL15296318, 16278539, 16319618, 16380333, 16551321, 16623366, 16696772. AKOLA RJ; PYB5PFI10414551, 16422168, 16567645, 16677239. AKOT - YOGIRAJ LAKADGANJ; PGJ6GOL15143306, 15480244, 16180728, 16186929, 16447523, 16576666, 16614027, 16650834, 16739247. ALMORA - BGL; P38EGOL16396940, 16598458, 16749682. ALWAR - AGARSEN CIRCLE; PJF4GOL13928821, 13926249, 13999104. AMARAVATI - PARATWADA ROAD; P071GOL12195290, 15194136, 16685597. AMBAJOGAI - MAIN ROAD; PLV8GOL14250376, 15292230, 16297022, 16401937, 16448627. AMBASAMUDRAM - NORTH CART STREET; PKD4SGL16187601, 16263006, 16648951, 16699681. AMBIKAPUR - AMBEDKAR CHOWK; PLI4GOL15478286, 16232049, 16654713. AMBUR - BYPASS ROAD; PJK1SGL16273979. AMRAVATI - BUS STAND ROAD; PEH8GOL16527154, 16546632, 16556266, 16604235, 16681431, 16727323, 16745874. AMRELI - STATION ROAD; PEL4GOL15530458, 16529491, 16574580, 16700706. AMRITSAR - CHEHHARTA ROAD; PFR9GOL15253013, 16213301, 16281445, 16401932, 16501311, 16547613, 16581043, 16576671. ANAND - A V ROAD; PGJ2GOL16651683, 16751432. ANANTPUR - SUBHASH ROAD; PGAT7SGL16202313, 16276597, 16296711, 16500473, 16579842, 16619219, 16619854, 16619535. ANGUL - GANDHI ROAD; PJD6SGL16326610, 16592790, 16687763, 16723128. Anjar - Varshamedhi Naka; P750GOL16416502, 16717576. ANKLESHWAR - ROSHNI PLAZA; PBX3GOL16521412. ANTA - MAIN ROAD; PJF6GOL15454025, 16319053. Anupgarh - Station Road; PEP4GOL15559492, 16339651, 16395380, 16528405, 16676944, 16744605, 16744836. Armoor - Ambedkar Chowrasta; PB56SGL16573422, 16703485, 16747200. ASSANDH - KARNAL ROAD; P20IGOL16176700, 16389283, 16522734, 16649631. ATHAGAD - BIRAKISHOREPUR; PCQ8SGL16169549, 16233454, 16426596, 16468789, 16552530, 16627755, 16569672, 16680089. AURANGABAD - BAJRANG CHOWK; PDA1GOL15483328, 16380812, 16750967. AURANGABAD - BANSILAL NAGAR; PCP7GOL15430438, 16678995. AURANGABAD - BEED BYPASS ROAD; PHI1GOL16167905, 16158911, 16389159, 16616957. BABRA - RAJKOT BHAYNAGAR HIGHWAY; P05VGOL14129110, 16342951, 16344442, 16339854, 16396337, 16396541, 16427285, 16430386, 16442103, 16525417, 16526334, 16543150, 16742218. BADARDA; PAZ1PFI12624242. BADVEL - FOUR ROAD CIRCLE; PJU6SGL12490693, 16542882, 16736873. BAGALKOT - VIDYAGIRI; PGC8SGL15457386, 16189595, 16401316, 16412956, 16453044, 16597098, 16696647, 16742113. BAGRU - MEENA MARKET; PCJF9GOL16413996, 16526071. BAHADURGARH - BGL; PNX2GOL16159392, 16413847, 16444140, 16574209. BALANGIR - GOPALJI ROAD; PJD7SGL15208065, 16339156, 16522977, 16654570. BALASORE - POLICE LINE SQUIRE; PEI4SGL16263200, 16296978, 16375261, 16619965. BALDA; PF36PFI15022463, 16419457, 16525653, 16578019, 16647901. BALLABGARH - AGRASEN CHOWK; PLP6GOL16257817, 16684938. BALOTRA - BGL; PNZ5GOL15020632, 16570380, 16598236, 16626227, 16743822. Balugaon - Main Road; PCQ9SGL16685620, 16740180. BANGLORE - HSR LAYOUT; PEX2SGL12315289, 16216358. Banswada - Bus Stand; PCV9SGL16187921, 16454449, 16620259. BARAN - KOTA ROAD; PCS4GOL16164122, 16203707, 16649537, 16697646. BARARA - RAILWAY ROAD; PBX6GOL15521048, 16258111, 16318380, 16643623, 16666002, 16699916, 16721135. BARDOLI; PG04GOL11167564, 11232992. BARGARH - KHARJATI KALA; PGC3SGL16233284, 16357740, 16550988, 16654601, 16697545. BARIPADA - KC CIRCLE; PMZ3SGL16176686. BARMER - VISHVKARMA CIRCLE; PCZ3GOL15218679, 15498536, 16642866, 16684523. BASAVAKALYAN - HARALAYYA CIRCLE; PER8SGL16280296, 16316923, 16395103, 16452730, 16453512, 16470128, 16750674. BASSI - BGL; PI4QGOL15372756, 15377300, 15379629, 16619998. 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BHIND - GWALIOR ROAD; POZ5GOL16642314, 16721390, 16747946. BHINDER - BGL; PC05GOL15502870, 16258506, 16401511. Bhodhan - Nanded Main Road; PEJ7SGL16393036, 16575697, 16706251, 16717766, 16725415. BHOPAL - IMAMI GATE; PFA6GOL16159788, 16374095, 16641416. BHOPAL - KAROD; PJD2GOL16231021. BIDAR - AMBDEKAR CIRCLE; P87QSGOL16348297, 16425537, 16477942, 16626117. BOBBILI - PEDA BAZAAR MAIN ROAD; PKI4SGL16309895, 16320516, 16555943. BUDHLADA - GRAIN MARKET; PYS2GOL16261480, 16723333. CHENGALPATTU - PERIYAR STREET; PE04SGL16318092. CHENNAI - AVADI; PLB6SGL16320483, 16678537. CHENNAI - JAFFERKHANPET; PLB7SGL16321435, 16739622. CHILAKALURIPET - NTR CENTER; P3U5SGL16400829, 16497144, 16556106. COIMBATORE - KAVUNDAM PALAYAM; PEJ2SGL16595652. Gadwal - Rajeev Marg; PLG4SGL16262438, 16523417, 16594173, 16601898, 16707017. GUDUR; PSNT7SGL11077555. GUNTAKAL - VEGETABLE MARKET; PBV9SGL13853488, 13892227, 15373531, 16389178, 16413492, 16544397. GUNTUR - VINUKONDA; PMM3SGL16545788. HINDUPUR - DHANA LAKSHMI ROAD; PEG4SGL14979371, 15169027, 16529987. KARAİKAL - CHURCH STREET; PCR5SGL15481873, 16502062. PANDAVESWAR; P21WGOL16697316. PAONTASAHIB - MAIN GURUDWARA ROAD; PBY2GOL14933646, 16162388, 16244037, 16236599, 16318866, 16442136. PONDICHERRY - EASWARAN KOIL STREET; PGH9SGL16444582. RAJULA - JAFRABAD ROAD; P70QGOL16212618, 16444359, 16502918, 16520924, 16647271, 16651899, 16699148, 16719292. (13-04-26) AURANGABAD - NIRALA BAZAR; PBS0GOL13997393, 14227908, 16427085, 15349769, 16427085, 16425445, 16605720, 16596128, 16677928, 16684871. AURANGABAD - PUNDLIK NAGAR ROAD; PEF8BGOL16210227. Baramati - Kachehi Road; P3G7JGOL15498874, 16306554, 16465467, 16548715, 16587733, 16652718, 16679809, 16684532, 16683609, 16720803, 16744597. BARODA - GENDA CIRCLE; PGI4GOL1439514, 15301878. BARSHI - BGL; PNX5GOL16206581, 16298406, 16338935. BARWALA - HANSI ROAD; PGP2GOL15198397, 16306189, 16391916, 16530927, 16594291. BASMAT - BGL; P6A4GOL16442824, 16570082, 16590654, 16682485. BAZPUR - GURUDWARA; PCY1GOL14939907, 15523255, 15524197, 15520051, 15523646, 16162477, 16400780, 16679222, 16741189. BEED - BARSHI ROAD; PF48GOL14969989, 16163925, 16400952, 16699433. BERHAMPUR - GOSANI NUAGAM; PMR7SGL15213101, 16279292, 16645819, 16654233, 16744855. Bhachau - Ramvadi; P78QGOL16448712, 16466787, 16475466, 16530144, 16698656. BHADKAD; PAE2PFI16184899, 16411615, 16532376, 16575126. BHADRAK - DHAMNAGAR; PML4SGL16726884. BHADRAK - SALANDI BYPASS; PCT1SGL1520968, 15499254, 16346256, 16412459, 16551934, 16619553, 16744547. BHANVAD - BUS STAND ROAD; P04VGOL16527768. BHARUCH - BGL; P460GOL16520411. BHATIYA - BUS STAND; PF41GOL16256693, 16286296. BHATPURE; PG53PFI16546395. BHAYNAGAR - SUBHASH NAGAR; PKQ2GOL1517543, 16203834, 16257071, 16367307, 16530194. BHAYNAGAR - WAGHWADI ROAD; PIT9GOL16423709, 16718227. BHAVNAGAR - VITTHALWADI ROAD; PB52GOL14975346, 16190843, 16594798. BHAWANIPATNA - BGL; PU41SGL15481881. BHIWADI - SAMTAL CHOWK; PCT6GOL15274940, 16160158, 16192570, 16259722, 16571758, 16448330, 16442811, 16500669, 16499281, 16717811. BHIWANDI - KALYAN NAKA; PEM9GOL16340403, 164445761. BHOGARAI - THANA CHOWK; PLP3SGL15117185, 16194596, 16253807, 16275753, 16422336, 16505691, 16525045, 16593293, 16696328. BHOPAL - MP NAGAR; PCA5GOL9173459, L9872010, 10213247, 16742449. BHUBAN - NUABAZAR; POF9SGL16185404, 16241380, 16472083, 16598145, 16593078, 16682313, 16719081. BHUBANESHWAR - KHANDAGIRI; PER5SGL14975572, 14976001, 15132708, 1578144, 15202303, 15553524, 15550470, 16190766. BHUJ - STATION ROAD; PEL5GOL15093277, 15270573, 16194029, 16255520, 16453467, 16551310. BIAORA - OLD AB ROAD; PMN3GOL16597980, 16748545. BIDAR - BUS STAND ROAD; PBY5SGL16699686. BIJAPUR - BAGALKOT CIRCLE; PLE1SGL16527552, 16621269, 16685453. BIJAPUR - SARAF BAZAR; PBV6SGL15146421, 15146900, 15418055, 15404630, 15506849, 15523260, 15529346, 16167792, 16166214, 16254186, 16257077, 16283243, 16296523, 16392769, 16455349, 16464447, 16545189, 16572760, 16699327, 16718210, 16746438. Bikaner - jasusir gate; PKH9GOL15121924, 16215081, 16233336, 16397249, 16399040, 16414014, 16451099, 16507693, 16579058, 16645279. BIKANER - JNV COLONY; POT2GOL16571832. BIKANER - KIRTI STAMBH; PB38GOL16549712, 16729612. BIKANER - KOTE GATE; P661GOL14979628, 15120441, 15178398, 16233874, 16397479, 16375459, 16420177, 16532304, 16545401, 16569262, 16622415, 16648746, 16676246. BIKANER - RANI BAZAR; PCS8GOL15167022, 15307460, 16454722, 15414663, 15411977, 16268621, 16263859, 16258244, 16451383, 16528701. BILASPUR - AGRASEN CHOWK; PGJ8GOL16183549, 16261879. BILASPUR - KAPAL MOCHAN ROAD; PPF1GOL16660403. BILASPUR - SARKANADA; P42HGOL16268807, 16502232, 16601877, 16653671. BINA - ETAWA STATION ROAD; PCA6GOL16399894. BOTAD - S T DEPO; PSJ2GOL16325023, 16644983. BOTAD - TOWER ROAD; PAU3GOL15130131, 15201604, 16184392, 16416405, 16595864. BULDHANA; PLBGOL15193958, 15238680. BUNDI - LANKA GATE; PCS3GOL15411608, 15558653, 16242104, 16326223, 16395529, 16453196, 16545945, 16650802, 16651747, 16716104. BYADAGI - BUS STAND CIRCLE; PKO3SGL16642149. Chakan - Manik Chowk; P30GGOL15000751, 15477323. CHALISGAON - GANULI WADA; PEN1GOL16187539, 16345798, 16368500, 16397997, 16572009, 16593760. CHANDGAD - GURUVAR PETH; PLR7GOL16622814, 16667578. CHANNARAYAPATNA - KALENAHALLI ROAD; PLM9SGL16432572. CHARKHI DADRI - BUS STAND; PNV1GOL16337259, 16372883, 16678292, 16737543. CHEEKA - KAITHAL ROAD; PGISGOL15097176, 15561439, 16281368, 16684794. CHHABRA - STATION ROAD; P3G1GOL16523659. CHHINDWARA - PARASIA ROAD; PEQ1GOL16187716, 16279657. CHICKMANGLUR - MG ROAD; PBV7SGL16298879. CHIKKABALLAPUR - BEERAPPA STREET; PE05SGL1274472, 12718234, 12819584, 13162800, 13162871, 13257175, 13903851. CHIMTHANE; PG52PFI16726853. 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DIDWANA - STATION ROAD; P5B5GOL14990950, 165455827, 16278426, 16520267, 16524964, 16571855, 16561600, 16719711, 16749659. DINDIGUL - NAGAL NAGAR; PED6SGL16591297. DUNGLEA; PYB4PFI16527999. ELLENABAD - SIRSA ROAD; PARGOL16175617, 16193186, 16209666, 16530592. ETAWA - MAIN ROAD; P3G2GOL16263359, 164499323, 16551771. FATEH GARH; PNA1PRN16280386, 16717643. Gajwel - Pichded; PEJ3SGL15072223, 15403966, 16378827, 16519241, 16523673, 16526615, 16592729, 16618209, 16644636, 16716322. GODAVARIKHANI - KALYAN NAGAR; PEK6SGL16528780. Haliya - Devarakonda Main Road; PGC7SGL16325893, 16503869, 16553761, 16686028. HOSUR - DENKANIKOTA MAIN ROAD; PCU4SGL16428897. Husnabad - Akkannapet Chowrasta; PCW5SGL16622688. HUZURABAD - WARANGAL ROAD; PJH1SGL16525298. KADIRI - NTR CIRCLE; PIW8SGL16571588, 16770357. Kaganazgar - Patel Road; PGM7SGL16695893. KAKINADA - JAGANNAIKPUR; PBW1SGL15504801. Kamareddy - Nizamsagar Road; P86QSGOL1512541, 16190316, 16471015, 16533996, 16591495. 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QUICKLY.

Vishal Mega Mart promoter sells 14% stake



Bengaluru: Vishal Mega Mart's largest promoter sold around 14 per cent of its stake via block deals for ₹7,636 crore on Friday, according to exchange data and Reuters calculations. Promoter Samayat Services LLP sold 652.5 million shares in Vishal Mega Mart at an average price of ₹117, a discount of 8.3 per cent to Thursday's close. Samayat Services held a 54.09 per cent stake prior to the sale. Vishal Mega Mart shares fell as much as 8.3 per cent before trimming losses to close down 7.7 per cent, following media reports of a discounted promoter sale. Buyers included HDFC Mutual Fund, the Government of Singapore and the Monetary Authority Of Singapore. REUTERS

TRUST Mutual Fund launches mid-cap NFO

Mumbai: TRUST Mutual Fund has launched Mid Cap Fund, an open-ended equity scheme that predominantly invest in mid-cap companies. The fund seeks to generate long-term capital appreciation by investing in equity and equity-related instruments of businesses ranked 101st to 250th in terms of full market capitalisation. The scheme will be benchmarked against the Nifty Midcap 150 TRI. The NFO opened for subscription on Friday. Mid-cap companies represent a distinctive stage in the corporate lifecycle, as they have generally moved beyond early uncertainty and are positioned for scalable expansion. Mid-caps in India have a market capitalisation of ₹34,800 crore to ₹1.04 lakh crore. OUR BUREAU

BROKER'S CALL.

Mirae Asset Sharekhan

GRAVITA (BUY)
Target: ₹2,000
CMP: ₹1,613.30
Gravita has acquired Rashtriya Metals Industries Ltd (RML), one of India's oldest copper manufacturers, for ₹565 crore (RML clocked a turnover of ₹910 crore in FY25). The deal marks Gravita's entry into the copper recycling business and will take its total copper capacity from 334 ktpa as of FY25-end to 340 ktpa. An additional 45 ktpa capacity will also be commissioned this quarter; both projects will be completely operational by Q2FY27. Gravita has expanded its lead recycling capacity by 80,300 tpa to 1,45,100 tpa, using internal accruals of ₹49 crore. The expansion would bolster its recycling capabilities in the long run, helping it to cater to rising demand for sustainable lead products. Gravita has also launched 6,000-tpa lithium-ion battery recycling plant at Mundra at an investment of about ₹14 crore. For Gravita, the rising supply of scrap resources, favourable policies, implementation of Battery Waste Management Rules, EPR, Reverse Charge Mechanism will boost output, while the Mundra plant will benefit from the focus on electric vehicles and clean energy. By FY29, the company eyes 50 per cent of its contributions from value-added products (VAPs). At CMP, Gravita trades at a 33x/27x multiple on FY27E/FY28E EPS. We maintain a Buy rating with a PT of ₹2,000 (28x on FY28E EPS).
Key Risks: Regulatory tailwinds on scrap procurement; Highly volatile global aluminium prices will tighten scrap availability that could affect procurement and processing volumes.

PL Capital

ELGI EQUIPMENTS (ACCUMULATE)
Target: ₹603
CMP: ₹534.35
We attended Elgi Equipments' analyst meet, where management highlighted business performance, product innovation and its medium-term strategic roadmap. The ISAAME region is expected to remain the key growth engine, supported by strong traction in the Middle East and a recovery in investment activity following tariff normalisation. In North America, performance was weighed down by the structurally lower-margin portable segment and prior tariff impacts; however, underlying initiatives remain intact. Europe has achieved break-even following cost rationalisation, with future growth anchored in market share gains across core markets. In Australia, share gains have partially mitigated broader market weakness. Rising traction for Demand-Match and a robust pipeline of new product launches position the company well to achieve its \$750 million revenue target with about 18 per cent EBITDA margin by FY31, reinforcing a constructive long-term outlook. The stock is currently trading at a PE of 36.0x/31.4x on FY27/28E earnings. We roll forward to Mar'28E and maintain our 'Accumulate' rating valuing the stock at a PE of 35x Mar'28E (35x Sep'27E) arriving at a revised TP of ₹603 (₹565 earlier).
Key challenges: Influx of low-priced Chinese imports in ISAAME region; Continued weakness in its Portable Business and slow recovery of service infrastructure in North America; and slow economic recovery in Europe due to geopolitical instability and uncertainty.

businessline is not responsible for the recommendations sourced from third party brokerages. Reports may be sent to: blmarketwatch@gmail.com

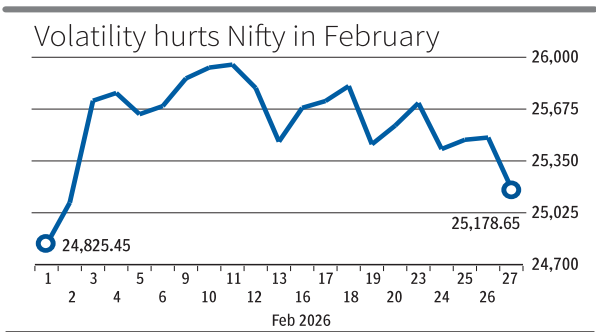
Sensex plunges 961 points; Nifty slips below 25,250 amid a broad sell-off

CONTRASTING STYLE. FPIs offload shares worth ₹7,500 cr; domestic institutions remain buyers at ₹12,292.81 cr

Anupama Ghosh Mumbai

Markets ended the week on a deeply negative note on Friday with the BSE Sensex crashing 961.42 points to close at 81,287.19, while the NSE Nifty 50 shed 317.90 points to settle at 25,178.65 — breaching the psychologically significant 25,200 mark and slipping below its 200-day EMA, a key long-term trend indicator signalling that sellers are firmly in control. The breakdown was sharp and broad-based, as traders shift to risk-off trading due to escalation of geopolitical tension involving Iran. Of the 4,369 stocks traded on the BSE, 2,633 declined against 1,574 advances, while 340 stocks hit fresh 52-week

lows compared to just 100 reaching new highs. Six stocks were locked in the lower circuit. The Nifty Midcap 100 and Nifty Smallcap 100 indices slipped 1.14 per cent and 1.10 per cent, respectively. Foreign institutional investors were aggressive sellers on the day, with FIIs/FPIs recording a provisional net sell of ₹7,536.36 crore in the cash segment. Domestic institutional investors, however, provided a significant counterweight, with DIIs logging a net buy of ₹12,292.81 crore. Ajit Mishra, SVP, Research, Religare Broking, noted that “a sharp bout of selling in the final hours dragged the index further down,” adding that “the Nifty has not only surrendered the support zone of



25,400 but has also moved closer to the gap area around the 25,100 mark.” Investor sentiment weakened due to a combination of factors including inconsistent foreign flows, weak global cues and lingering geopolitical tensions. The underperformance of select heavyweights across sectors further intensified the decline, he added.

Sectorally, realty, auto, FMCG, metal, banking and telecom indices fell between 1 and 2 per cent.

NIFTY MOVERS
IT, media and consumer durables were the rare bright spots. Among Nifty losers, Adani Enterprises fell the most, dropping 2.68 per cent, followed by Maruti Suzuki,

which lost 2.5 per cent. Bharti Airtel declined 2.47 per cent, Grasim slipped 2.43 per cent and Sun Pharma dropped 2.40 per cent. However, Trent led with a rise of 1.35 per cent, followed by Infosys, which advanced 0.76 per cent. HCL Technologies edged up 0.62 per cent, Apollo Hospitals gained 0.55 per cent and Eternal rose 0.41 per cent. Vinod Nair, Head of Research at Geojit Investments, attributed the week's volatility to “changing global cues, renewed tariff uncertainty and concerns over AI-driven disruption,” while flagging that “today's better-than-expected India GDP print, signalling resilient underlying economic activity, offers a measure of domestic support even as global risks remain elevated.”

CA body flags hurdles in research analyst registration

Akshata Gorde Mumbai

The Bombay Chartered Accountants' Society (BCAS) has written to Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) raising several regulatory and practical difficulties faced by applicants seeking registration as research analysts, and has sought clarifications and procedural changes to streamline the process. The CA's body said prospective applicants are facing challenges ranging from delays in application processing to interpretational issues around eligibility and permitted activities under the SEBI (Research Analysts) Regulations, 2014. One of the key concerns raised is the absence of a structured framework for individuals registered as research analysts to transition into corporate or LLP structures. BCAS said the current system requires fresh registration and surrender of the earlier licence without any transition window, which can disrupt services to existing clients and create operational difficulties.

ADVISERS FRAMEWORK
The body has suggested a mechanism similar to the one available under the investment advisers framework, where applicants can obtain in-principle approval while continuing to service clients during the transition period. BCAS has also sought clarification on restrictions relating to “other employment” of the principal officer of a research analyst entity. According to the representation, applications are being rejected in cases where the proposed principal officer holds directorships or partnership interests in other entities.

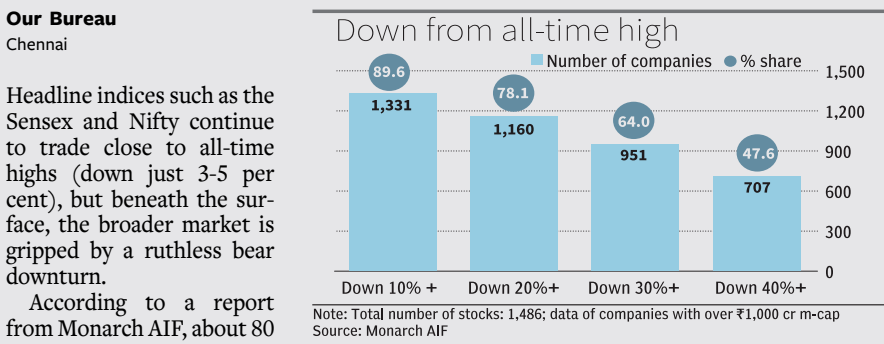
One of the key concerns is the absence of a structured framework for individuals registered as research analysts

The society said that the regulations do not explicitly prohibit such positions, particularly when they are non-executive in nature. Another issue raised relates to delays in processing applications after the responsibility for administration of research analyst registrations was delegated to BSE. BCAS said the process now involves scrutiny by both BSE and SEBI, which has lengthened timelines compared with earlier when the regulator handled registrations directly. The representation also sought clarity on whether a single individual can act as principal officer for the research analyst division as well as other divisions within the same entity, stating that the current interpretation by the exchange appears inconsistent with the regulatory framework.

INVESTOR TRAINING
BCAS further sought guidance on whether investor training programmes using live market data and providers of so-called “black box” algorithmic strategies should fall within the scope of research analyst activities. In addition, the body has requested SEBI to clarify whether authorised persons of stock brokers and entities whose directors are registered mutual fund distributors can obtain research analyst registration, provided conflict-of-interest safeguards are in place.

‘80% of stocks under bear grip despite Nifty near all-time high’

Good opportunities emerge as several small firms are now available at one-year forward P/E of less than 20x



Our Bureau
Chennai
Headline indices such as the Sensex and Nifty continue to trade close to all-time highs (down just 3-5 per cent), but beneath the surface, the broader market is gripped by a ruthless bear downturn. According to a report from Monarch AIF, about 80 per cent of the listed universe above ₹1,000-crore market capitalisation (m-cap) is in bear market category and would appear even more bleak if the com-

panies below the ₹1,000-crore m-cap are included. Indian markets have witnessed a phase of time and value correction in the last

18 months (since September 2024), with a peculiar phenomenon where broader listed universe is in bear market territory while in-

dices are staying near all-time/52-week highs, it said, adding surprisingly the correction in main indices has been much lower at 3-5 per cent range and even the Nifty small-cap index has fallen only 13 per cent from its all-time highs! “This kind of divergence is very rare and within each index, a narrow band of stocks have been driving the index returns in the last 9-12 months, while broader market remains in bear grip,” it further said. The analysis by Monarch AIF shows that currently

about 36 per cent of all stocks above ₹1,000-crore m-cap are trading at TTM P/E of below 25x (vs 25 per cent in September 2024). “This has made risk-reward favourable for bottoms-up stock picking, like it generally happens after any bear market.” Monarch AIF believes that broader markets have been in bear territory for the past few months and good opportunities are now emerging, as several small yet fast-growing companies are now available at one-year forward P/E of less than 20x.

Video KYC, shorter OFS timelines clear path for XED's Gift City IPO

Avinash Nair Ahmedabad

Video KYC, shorter OFS timelines and easier demat account rules are among the regulatory tweaks that have cleared the path for XED Executive Development Ltd to launch its first IPO in Gift City this March, making it the first Indian company to test the waters in the International Financial Services Centre. The promoters — John Kalleilil and Chief Financial Officer Piyush Agrawal, classmates from Bassi School in Vadodara — say these adjustments were critical in enabling the offering for global investors. “We faced practical hurdles that no one had encountered before,” said Kalleilil, based in New York.

OVERSEAS INVESTORS
“For instance, many of our overseas investors didn't have demat accounts in India. IFSCA allowed applications without an existing demat for this IPO, which was a huge relief. They also permitted video KYC, a six-month OFS instead of the earlier



John Kalleilil, Founder & MD, XED

one-year window, and extended the acceptable age of financial statements from 135 to 180 days. These tweaks made it feasible to go ahead with our IPO,” he added. The company's IPO opens on March 6 and closes on March 18. It has set a price band of \$10-10.5 per share. Kalleilil and Agrawal, along with colleagues from the Indian School of Business and IIT-Kanpur, have expanded XED's operations globally — from India and Singapore to the US and Middle East — offering customised programmes with universities like Oxford, Cornell, Carnegie Mellon, and Singapore Management University. Kalleilil said about 50-60 per cent of XED's revenue comes from public pro-

grammes and 40-50 per cent from enterprise programmes delivered worldwide. **OFFSHORE LISTING**
The Gift City IPO is being positioned primarily for NRIs and foreign investors, with India-based residents ineligible to participate due to offshore listing rules. “Our target market is the Middle East, particularly the UAE, and Southeast Asia,” Agrawal said. “We are also engaging distributors to eventually expand access in the US,” he said. Apart from raising capital, the company plans to invest part of the proceeds in creating dedicated executive education campuses. XED is raising \$12 million in total through the IPO, including a 0.6 million-share allocation for market-making purposes. “This ensures liquidity for investors post-listing,” Agrawal said. Of the total, 9.6 million is a fresh issue to fund growth, while the remaining 2.4 million comes from an offer-for-sale to early angel investors. Post-IPO, the promoters together will hold around 60-63 per cent of the company.

Sri Lanka's first blue bond makes debut on NSE IX

Avinash Nair Ahmedabad

Sri Lanka's first blue bond — an LKR 3 billion issuance by DFCC Bank — has been dually listed on the NSE International Exchange (NSE IX) at Gift City, marking the first blue bond to be admitted for trading within India's International Financial Services Centre (IFSC) jurisdiction. The dual listing has been facilitated under a memorandum of understanding exchanged between NSE IX and the Colombo Stock Exchange (CSE) at Gift City on Friday, which is aimed at strengthening cross-border capital market collaboration, enabling dual listings, and promoting innovative financial products across jurisdictions.

INVESTOR ACCESS
Primarily listed on CSE, the bond's admission on NSE IX expands its international visibility and investor access, while reinforcing Gift City's growing role as a platform for sustainable finance instruments.

DFCC Bank in November 2025 had introduced the blue bonds to finance the sustainable use of marine resources, supply of clean drinking water, aquatic pollution control and the promotion of related sustainable economic activities, while offering an attractive return to investors. **MARINE PROTECTION**
Blue bonds, a subset of green bonds, channel proceeds specifically toward marine conservation, sustainable fisheries, ocean-based economic activity and broader water-related environmental projects. The listing is expected to help diversify the investor base by enabling participation through Gift City's offshore regulatory framework. Earlier, in June 2025, NSE IX hosted DFCC Bank PLC's leadership at Gift IFSC to mark the landmark listing of its LKR 2.5 billion foreign-currency green bonds — Sri Lanka's first renewable energy-focused capital market debt instrument and the first foreign corporate issuance admitted to trading on the exchange.

SEBI updates norms for independent reviewers of green debt securities

Our Bureau Mumbai

The Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) has revised norms governing the appointment of independent third-party reviewers or certifiers for green debt securities, aligning them with the broader framework for ESG debt instruments. In a circular, SEBI said the guidelines have been modified to bring consistency with the requirements applicable to social bonds and sustainability bonds. It mandates issuers to appoint an independent third-party reviewer to confirm that green debt issuances comply with

the definition under SEBI's Non-Convertible Securities Regulations, 2021. The reviewer must be independent of the issuer's management, remunerated in a conflict-free manner, and possess expertise in assessing ESG debt securities. The scope of review must be disclosed in the offer document. Permissible forms of external review include second party opinions, verification (including for refinancing), certification and scoring or rating, in line with International Capital Market Association guidelines. The new provisions take effect immediately.

Gaudium IVF lists 5% higher, but surrenders gains to end at ₹80.48

Our Bureau Chennai

Shares of Gaudium IVF and Women Health made a decent debut on the bourses on Friday. After listing with a 5 per cent premium at ₹83 on the BSE, the stock further rose to ₹87.25, but surrendered almost all the gains to close at ₹80.48, up 1.87 per cent, against the IPO price of ₹79. On the NSE, the shares of fertility services provider ended at ₹80.26, up 1.59 per cent. The ₹165 crore IPO of Gaudium IVF was subscribed 7.27 times, thanks to a strong interest from non-institutional and retail investors. The retail portion was subscribed 7.6 times, while the non-institutional investor



NEW BORN. Manika Khanna, Founder and CEO, Gaudium IVF, with Sriram Krishnan, Chief Business Development Officer, NSE, at the listing ceremony. The stock closed 1.9% higher

(NII) by 14.05 times. The quota for qualified institutional buyers received bids for 1.62 times. Ahead of the public issue, Gaudium IVF raised ₹49.5 crore from anchor investors. The anchor participants include Meru Investment Fund, PCC-Cell, Sanshi Fund I, Hornbill Orchid India Fund and Carnelian India Multi

Strategy Fund. The IPO that hit the market at a price band of ₹75-79 comprised a fresh issue of 1.14 crore shares and an offer for sale of nearly 95 lakh shares by promoter Manika Khanna. Proceeds from the fresh issue will be used to set up 19 IVF centres across India, repay debt and meet general corporate expenses, the company said.

Nifty 50 Movers					▼ 317.90 pts.
	Close(F)	Pts	PE	WN(%)	
Infosys	1300.10	8.45	18.82	3.97	
HCL Tech	1389.10	3.61	22.89	1.28	
Trent Ltd.	3999.50	2.12	85.58	0.75	
Apollo Hosp	7821.50	1.05	60.28	0.70	
NTPC	381.90	0.00	14.92	1.58	
Wipro	200.96	-0.08	15.81	0.50	
Eternal Ltd.	246.30	-0.32	1028.95	1.54	
ONGC	279.70	-0.34	7.82	0.95	
Jio Financial Services Ltd.	255.40	-0.54	101.11	0.73	
Tech Mahindra	1357.80	-0.35	28.13	0.75	
Cipla	1348.20	-1.22	24.02	0.66	
Titan	4327.50	-1.37	80.61	1.56	
Coal India	430.65	-1.42	8.92	0.85	
Asian Paints	2376.20	-1.85	58.29	0.94	
L&T	4278.30	-2.11	31.01	4.38	
TCS	2637.40	-2.31	19.90	2.35	
Tata Motors	1141.00	-2.64	76.73	0.65	
Max Healthcare	1091.95	-2.93	74.85	0.71	
Adani Enter	2161.80	-3.12	17.66	0.49	
JSW Steel	1264.70	-3.28	39.82	1.04	
Bajaj Auto	9972.50	-3.34	31.35	0.96	
Bharat Elec	444.70	-3.42	54.51	1.39	
Tata Motors PV	208.75	-4.08	52.04	0.67	
Nestle India	1291.70	-4.14	76.37	0.81	
Dr Reddys Lab	1286.30	-4.41	19.44	0.68	
HDFC Life	715.30	-4.41	81.52	0.67	
SBI Life	2037.20	-4.49	83.27	0.80	
PowerGrid Corp	298.65	-4.57	17.89	1.18	
Adani Ports	1521.00	-4.79	28.04	0.98	
Hindalco	924.70	-5.27	12.92	1.17	
Int'l GlobeAvi	4627.20	-5.27	58.12	0.95	
Grasim Ind	2799.80	-5.34	20.12	0.93	
Eicher Motors	8010.50	-5.42	41.01	0.96	
Tata Steel	212.33	-5.78	29.06	1.53	
Bajaj Finserv	1993.40	-6.01	16.59	0.99	
UltraTech Cement	679.70	-6.38	48.75	1.31	
State Bank	1201.70	-7.10	12.82	4.34	
Axis Bank	1383.90	-7.29	16.26	3.46	
Shriram Finance Ltd.	1079.40	-7.74	22.20	1.32	
Hind Unilever	2338.10	-8.80	54.64	1.81	
Bajaj Finance	995.90	-9.93	33.82	2.30	
ITC	380.85	-9.98	28.84	2.63	
Maruti Suzuki	14657.00	-10.25	31.28	1.70	
Sun Pharma	1737.00	-11.31	38.05	1.60	
Kotak Bank	415.20	-15.08	21.97	2.66	
M&M	3397.40	-17.08	24.99	2.64	
Reliance Ind	1393.90	-19.11	19.29	8.20	
Bharti Airtel	1879.30	-30.75	28.92	4.56	
HDFC Bank	887.75	-36.84	30.74	11.63	
ICICI Bank	1378.90	-40.74	17.42	8.58	

Nifty Next 50 Movers					▼ 917.60 pts.
	Close(F)	Pts	PE	WN(%)	
Siemens	3418.60	21.66	76.79	1.30	
Indian Oilcorp	187.47	11.21	7.18	3.01	
Siemens Energy India	2930.90	2.81	88.36	1.12	
Indian Railway Finance Corp	103.55	1.72	19.31	0.80	
Bajaj Housing Finance	87.04	-1.49	29.27	0.35	
Cg Power & Ind Sol	725.20	-3.19	102.94	2.14	
Gail (India)	169.53	-3.48	12.95	1.97	
Bpcl	385.40	-3.49	6.79	3.22	
Mazagon Dock	2224.90	-6.11	37.29	0.73	
United Spirits	1380.80	-7.08	58.39	1.76	
Hindus Zinc	603.80	-7.80	21.62	1.13	
AvenueSuper	3847.60	-7.95	87.41	2.44	
Bosch	36425.00	-8.20	38.97	1.36	
Abb India	6073.00	-9.44	76.31	1.37	
Punjab Natl Bank	129.44	-10.76	8.32	1.92	
LtImidtree	4462.00	-11.89	28.00	1.78	
Hyundai Motor India	12165.40	-12.32	30.39	1.33	
Havells	1397.10	-12.56	59.10	1.52	
Zyduslifesciences	921.70	-12.61	18.45	0.99	
Adani Energy Solutions	1011.55	-12.91	50.98	1.51	
Dif	603.85	-13.38	33.75	1.67	
Bank Of Baroda	321.85	-13.92	8.48	2.57	
Lic	849.40	-14.29	10.36	0.81	
Tata Power	377.55	-14.36	24.09	2.73	
Adani Power	140.11	-14.56	23.91	2.38	
Canara Bank	157.37	-15.27	7.75	2.28	
Rural Elec	349.80	-16.11	5.34	1.88	
AdaniGreenenergy	947.35	-17.11	84.08	1.25	
Jsw Energy	487.75	-17.55	32.74	1.13	
Solar Industries	138.75	-19.84	80.04	1.42	
Jindal Steel	1244.20	-18.84	62.95	2.00	
Bajaj Holdings	10804.00	-19.10	13.42	2.01	
Macrotech Developers	988.25	-19.62	29.50	1.20	
Torrent Pharma	4333.30	-20.87	64.55	1.95	
Ambuja Cements	500.40	-21.50	25.13	1.31	
Cholamandalam&fin	1730.75	-21.95	17.64	2.55	
Pidilifill	1492.00	-23.20	65.62	1.39	
Info Edge I	1029.60	-24.94	39.62	1.72	
Divis Lab	6408.50	-24.97	68.63	1.50	
Godrej Consumer	1217.50	-26.20	68.39	2.11	
Samvardhathersoninternat	133.34	-26.25	38.67	2.55	
Shree Cement	2603.55	-26.88	52.38	1.50	
Power Finance	413.80	-29.14	4.09	2.59	
icici Lombard Gic	1901.50	-32.68	33.81	1.98	
Indian Hotels Co.	667.05	-36.63	43.87	2.52	
Varun Beverages	451.40	-37.16	49.86	2.66	
Britannia Ind	6002.50	-47.59	59.83	3.05	
Hindustanasearonautics	393.20	-54.48	29.42	3.20	
Ts Motor Corp	3819.70	-59.52	60.21	3.91	
Vedanta	718.40	-96.36	16.95	5.25	
Pfts: Impact on index movement					

QUICKLY.

BoB eyes up to ₹10,000 cr via green infra bonds

Mumbai: Bank of Baroda plans to raise up to ₹10,000 crore through issuance of green infrastructure bonds on March 4. The base issue size is ₹5,000 crore, with a green shoe option to retain over-subscription of up to ₹5,000 crore. Bonds will have a tenor of seven years and are scheduled to mature on March 5, 2033. The pay-in and allotment date is March 5, 2026. [PTI](#)

SC junks SpiceJet's plea against ₹144 cr deposit

New Delhi: The Supreme Court on Friday junked a plea filed by SpiceJet Ltd and its Chairman Ajay Singh challenging an order by the Delhi High Court to deposit ₹144.5 crore in the arbitration dispute with Kalanithi Maran and KAL Airways Pvt Ltd. A bench upheld the January 19 HC order and imposed costs of ₹1 lakh on Singh for pursuing the litigation endlessly. [PTI](#)

‘AI adoption high in India, growth ahead of global trends’

Sindhu Hariharan
Chennai

India is growing at a much faster pace than global markets for us, signalling that the adoption of Enterprise AI and managed data cloud platforms is leapfrogging here, Snowflake India MD Vijayant Rai said.

“We work with some of the largest digital natives in the country, and they serve 90 to 100 million customers on a daily basis using the data and AI cloud platform, which we provide,” Rai told *businessline*.

PM urges India Inc to step up investment in infra, innovation

ROAD AHEAD. Moots stakeholders’ participation for reforms to translate into results

Shishir Sinha
New Delhi

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Friday called on India Inc to ramp up investments significantly, while also emphasising the need for excellence in delivery and execution.

Addressing the first post-Budget webinar on ‘Technology, Reforms and Finance for Viksit Bharat’, he emphasised that while any policy could create a framework, its ultimate success depends on the active participation of all stakeholders.

He called upon the industry to step forward with fresh investment and innovation, while urging financial institutions and analysts to assist in preparing practical solutions and strengthening market confidence.

“When the government, industry and knowledge



Prime Minister Narendra Modi

partners move forward in unison, reforms are successfully converted into results. Budget announcements are converted into tangible results on the ground only through this collective synergy,” Modi asserted.

LONG-TERM ASSETS

Highlighting the government’s commitment to building long-term productive assets, he pointed out the significant rise in public capital expenditure. “Over the last 11 years, the provision has grown from approxi-

mately ₹2 lakh crore to over ₹12 lakh crore in the current Budget. This investment serves as a clear signal for the private sector to increase participation in infrastructure and innovation.”

He called upon the industry and financial institutions to come forward with new energy, emphasising the need for greater participation in infrastructure, innovation in financing models and stronger collaboration in emerging sectors.

He said project sanction methodology and appraisal

quality must be strengthened, keeping cost-benefit analysis and life-cycle costing paramount.

Modi said India’s resilience over the past decade was driven by conviction-led reforms and sustained efforts to improve ease of doing business.

“To sustain the reform express momentum, we not only need to focus on policy intent but also have to focus on delivery excellence. The evaluation of reforms should be on the basis its impact on the ground,” he said.

He proposed the creation of a ‘Reform Partnership Charter’ to formalise collaboration among government, industry, financial institutions and academia as part of the goal of achieving Viksit Bharat by 2047. Modi added that when government, industry and knowledge partners come together, “reforms translate into results.”

Bank credit to micro, small industry up 29.2% in first 10 months of FY26

Sourashis Banerjee
Chennai

Total bank credit to industries grew 10.1 per cent in the first 10 months of FY26, up from the 6.3 per cent growth seen in the corresponding period of FY25.

Micro and small industries (MSE), which have 23.5 per cent share in outstanding bank credit to industry, recorded 29.2 per cent growth between April 2025 to January 2026. This is sharply higher than the 7.2 per cent growth recorded in the same period in FY25. Outstanding credit to this segment rose from ₹7.98 lakh crore towards the end of March 2025 to ₹10.31 lakh crore by the end of January 2026.

DATA FOCUS.

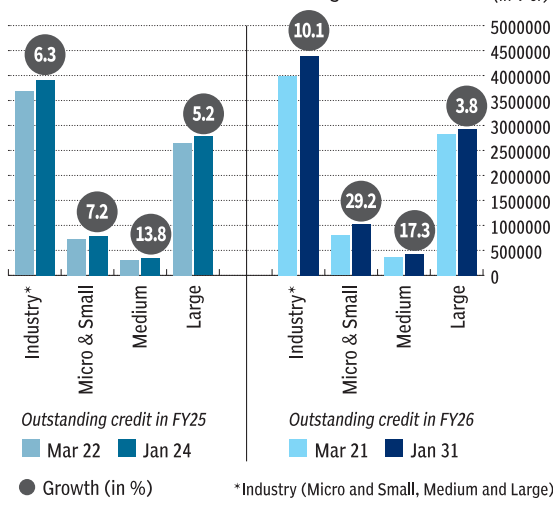
Several policy measures seem to have helped the growth in MSE credit. It was announced in the 2025 Budget that the coverage will be increased from ₹5 crore to ₹10 crore under the Credit Guarantee Scheme – I to all guarantees approved on or after April 01, 2025, including enhancement in working capital.

In FY24–25, Credit Guarantee Fund Trust for Micro and Small Enterprises (CGTMSSE) approved a record ₹3.06 lakh crore in credit guarantees. However, VN Shiva Shankar, Senior Vice-President of the Southern India Chamber of Commerce and Industry, said that although the “CGTMSSE limit increase was impactful, the increase in the ceiling for MUDRA scheme from ₹10 lakh to ₹20 lakh was more impactful.”

FORMALISATION HELPS
Some experts think that increasing formalisation is also

In the fast lane

Credit to micro and small industries grew the fastest (in ₹ cr)



Source: RBI

helping the growth of MSE loans. “Micro and small enterprises are leading the recent growth in industrial credit primarily because they are expanding from a smaller base and benefiting from rapid formalisation,” said Shachindra Nath, MD of UGRO Capital.

“In this aspect UDYAM registrations have been extremely helpful. MSMEs have now seen that some of the larger players are even going for listing, incentivising higher formalisation,” said Shankar.

He added, “The banks have also been searching for good MSMEs to lend. However, the ability to do a credit risk assessment or the conviction that they can lend and they can collect was missing. Trade Receivables Discounting System platform is a game changer in this regard as it frees MSMEs from the working capital requirements, easing security fears of banks.”

Sarvadnya Kulkarni, CEO of General Instruments Consortium, a MSME, said,

“The increase in MSME credit is closely aligned with the revival in industrial capex. Sectors such as oil & gas, power, chemicals and infrastructure have seen stronger project execution, and MSMEs operating within these are drawing higher working capital. Export growth has also contributed significantly as engineering MSMEs are expanding deliveries, which requires enhanced inventory funding.”

Medium industries also recorded robust credit growth at 17.3 per cent in the first ten months. Outstanding credit to this segment stood at ₹4.26 lakh crore towards the end of January 2026, accounting for 9.7 per cent share.

Credit growth to large industries, however, declined to 3.8 per cent, lower than last year’s 5.2 per cent growth in the first ten months of FY26. But large industries still account for more than two-third share of all outstanding bank credit to industries.

Galaxy Health eyes ₹150 cr premium by FY26-end

Sindhu Hariharan
Chennai

Galaxy Health Insurance, a standalone health insurer just about 16 months into operation, is set to close FY26 with about ₹150 crore in premium. The company is looking to clock about ₹350 crore in premium for FY27.

Jointly promoted by the families of TVS’ Venu Srinivasan and Star Health

founder V Jagannathan, the insurer currently recorded about ₹125 crore in premium, with one month remaining in the fiscal.

With about 3.5 lakh policyholders currently, Galaxy has customers across eight States and has an average ticket size of around ₹18,000 per policy, G Srinivasan, MD and CEO, Galaxy Health Insurance, told *businessline*.

“We have so far settled

about 15,000 claims in the current year, and there have been no grievances on our claims. And if a customer claims ₹100, we have been able to pay almost 98.6,” said Srinivasan, indicating that there is a wide perception that insurers only pay about 70-80 per cent.

The response of the GST cut on insurance was very positive from the customer side, he said, noting that, as a

company, they have not reduced agents’ commission and absorbed the impact of not having input credit set-off.

“It is about about 6 per cent of our premium as impact on the bottom line, and we have absorbed it,” he said.

With regard to 100 per cent FDI now allowed in insurance, he said they are strongly capitalised by the promoters at the moment.

‘Our aim is to grow assets, liabilities in line with the market in FY27; gain market share in FY28’

bl interview

Piyush Shukla
Mumbai

IndusInd Bank is aiming to rejuvenate business growth, in line with the banking industry in FY27 and gain market share in FY28, says MD & CEO Rajiv Anand.

The bank’s loans deposits de-grew on a yearly basis in Q3 FY26 as the management focused on making significant changes in the leadership team. Anand talks about the bank’s business strategy after it suffered material losses due to the discrepancies found in its derivatives portfolio last year and the possibility of raising capital going ahead.

Edited excerpts:

When do you see business growth reviving?

There has been a significant change in the team, both on the assurance and business side. By March 31, a brand new team will be in place. The intent of the team is to rejuvenate growth, not just for this year but for the foreseeable future. Our aim is to grow assets and liabilities in line with the market in FY27, and start to gain market share in FY28. And then dominate in some of our focused areas in the third year.

What would be the split between secured and unsecured loans?

The vehicle finance business is around ₹1 lakh crore; corporate loans book is around ₹1.3 lakh crore, microfinance



We will continue to focus on improving product offering for customers, improving productivity at branches

RAJIV ANAND
MD & CEO, IndusInd Bank



business is about ₹20,000 crore and all other retail businesses are about ₹50,000 crore. We have a big opportunity to grow our SME loans, secured retail advances such as gold loans, affordable housing etc.

Our largest portion within unsecured loans is micro loans which we expect to form 7-8 per cent of our loan book. We also understand these loans are cyclical in nature, so we have started to use the credit guarantee scheme. As of now 38 per cent of micro loan book is covered under the credit guarantee scheme and we expect it to be fully covered under the scheme next year. Micro loan segment also helps us meeting PSL guidelines, both agri and small and marginal farmers. Further, slippages have reduced in the micro loan segment in the industry over the last year.

Credit cards are a very large part of our portfolio and it is a critical instrument to maintain engagement with our existing customers. We will be cautiously growing this segment as risk appears elevated in industry. There is a difference now in

the way we are building our credit cards business. Earlier, a pre-dominant part of the business was coming from new to bank customers, now we are pivoting to building business on the back of servicing existing customers. We will add roughly 150,000 customers at the bank each month, which gives us a large opportunity to engage with this customer base.

How do you plan to reduce the share of bulk deposits?

We have the brand, and distribution of little over 3,000 branches across country. In specific context of our bank, it becomes very critical because we also have a fairly lumpy liability franchise where we have bulk deposits and intent is on reducing dependence on such deposits. We will continue to focus on improving product offering for customers, improving productivity at branches, enhancing salary accounts and getting government business. We are also tapping start-ups, all these measures are towards gaining stickier retail deposits, and it will re-

duce our cost of funds going forward.

Guidance on NIM...

We are focused on improving return on assets (RoA). As mentioned, we are targeting to grow in-line with industry in FY27 and exiting next fiscal with 1 per cent RoA. As we think about more granular asset businesses, diversifying asset businesses, NIMs could be somewhat lower but we have ample opportunity to be able to make up for it due to lower cost to assets and lower credit cost.

Will you do more leadership hiring?

We have on-boarded a new chief risk officer-designate, as existing CRO will retire in next fiscal. And we have a new chief information officer. We expect more senior leadership hires in retail segment.

When do you plan to raise capital? How much weight do promoters carry in making strategic, important decisions?

As far as capital is concerned, at this moment we don’t need capital. Will we require it after 18-24 months? By then we would anticipate that growth has come back and it is under those circumstances that we would need capital. Once we decide to raise capital, the question is whether it should be done from a strategic investor or a QIP or other avenues. All decisions that impact IndusInd Bank have to be decided by the Board.

HINDUSTAN OIL EXPLORATION COMPANY LIMITED
(CIN: L11100GJ1996PLC029880)
Registered Office: ‘HOEC House’, Tondajai Road, Vadodara – 390 020, Gujarat, India
Chennai Office: ‘Lakshmi Chambers’, 192, St. Mary’s Road, Alwarpet, Chennai – 600 018, Tamil Nadu, India. Phone: 044-66229000, Fax: 044-66229011/12
E-mail: hoecshare@hoec.com, Website: www.hoec.com

POSTAL BALLOT NOTICE AND REMOTE E-VOTING INFORMATION

NOTICE is hereby given that pursuant to the provisions of Sections 108, 110 and other applicable provisions, if any, of the Companies Act, 2013, (“the Act”) read with Rules 20 and 22 of the Companies (Management and Administration) Rules, 2014 (“the Rules”) and other applicable Rules, General Circular Nos. 14/2020 dated April 8, 2020, 17/2020 dated April 13, 2020, 20/2020 dated May 5, 2020, and subsequent circulars issued by the Ministry of Corporate Affairs, the latest being 03/2025 dated September 22, 2025 (collectively referred to as “MCA Circulars”), Regulation 44 of the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015 (“SEBI Listing Regulations”), Secretarial Standard on General Meetings issued by The Institute of Company Secretaries of India (“SS-2”), and other applicable laws, rules and regulations (including any statutory modification(s) or re-enactment(s) thereof for the time being in force), approval of the Members is being sought to transact the special businesses as set out in the Postal Ballot Notice by passing Resolutions by way of Postal Ballot only by voting through electronic means (“remote e-Voting”).

The Company has, on February 27, 2026 sent the Postal Ballot Notice by e-mail to all Members whose e-mail addresses are registered with the Company / Depository Participants. In compliance with the MCA Circulars, this Postal Ballot Notice is being sent only through electronic mode to those members whose names appear on the register of members / register of beneficial owners as on **Friday, February 20, 2026 (“Cut-Off Date”)** received from the Depositories and whose e-mail address is registered with the Company / Registrar and Transfer Agent / Depository Participants / Depositories. Physical copies of the Postal Ballot Notice along with postal ballot forms and prepaid business reply envelopes are not being sent to members for this Postal Ballot.

Members who have not registered their e-mail addresses so far are requested to register their e-mail address with DP / Registrar & Share Transfer Agent - MUGF Intime India Private Limited (formerly known as Link Intime India Private Limited) for receiving all communication from the Company electronically.

The Company has engaged the services of Central Depository Services (India) Limited, (“CDSL”) to provide remote e-voting facility to its Members.

The Notice is also available on the Company’s website at www.hoec.com, websites of the Stock Exchanges i.e. BSE Limited and National Stock Exchange of India Limited at www.bseindia.com and www.nseindia.com respectively, and on the website of CDSL at www.evotingindia.com.

Only a person, whose name is recorded in the register of members / register of beneficial owners, as on the Cut-Off Date, maintained by the Depositories shall be entitled to participate in the remote e-voting. A person who is not a member as on the Cut-Off Date, should treat this Postal Ballot Notice for information purpose only.

Members are hereby informed that:

- The businesses as set out in the notice shall be transacted only through remote e-voting system;
- The remote e-voting shall commence on **Saturday, February 28, 2026 at 9:00 a.m. and end on Sunday, March 29, 2026 at 5:00 p.m.**
- The remote e-voting module shall be disabled by CDSL beyond 5:00 p.m. on March 29, 2026.
- Once the vote on a resolution is cast by a member, he/she shall not be allowed to change it subsequently.
- The voting rights of members shall be in proportion to their share of the paid-up value of equity share capital of the Company as on the cut-off date.

The detailed procedure / instructions for remote e-voting are contained in the Notice of Postal Ballot.

The Board of Directors of the Company have appointed M/s. S. Sandeep and Associates, Practicing Company Secretaries, as the scrutinizer to conduct the Postal Ballot through remote e-voting process in a fair and transparent manner.

The result of the Postal Ballot along with the Scrutinizer’s Report will be displayed on the Company’s website at www.hoec.com and shall be communicated to the Stock Exchanges where the Company’s shares are listed i.e. BSE Limited at www.bseindia.com and National Stock Exchange of India Limited at www.nseindia.com, within two working days from the conclusion of the Postal Ballot.

The resolutions passed by the Members through Postal Ballot shall be deemed to have been passed as if the same were passed at a general meeting of the Members convened in that regard. The resolutions, if passed by requisite majority, will be deemed to have been passed on the last date of remote e-voting i.e. Sunday, March 29, 2026.

If you have any queries or issues regarding Postal Ballot & e-Voting from the CDSL e-Voting System, you can write an email to helpdesk.evoting@cdslindia.com or contact at toll free no. 1800 22 55 33. All grievances connected with the facility for voting by electronic means may be addressed to Mr. Rakesh Dalvi, Manager, Central Depository Services (India) Limited, A Wing, 25th Floor, Marathon Futrex, Mafatal Mill Compounds, N M Joshi Marg, Lower Parel (East), Mumbai – 400013; e-mail ID: helpdesk.evoting@cdslindia.com or call at toll free no. 1800 21 09911.

By order of the Board of Directors
For **HINDUSTAN OIL EXPLORATION COMPANY LIMITED**
Sd/-
G. Josephin Daisy
Company Secretary

Place : Chennai
Date : February 28, 2026


Sakthi Finance
Since 1955

SAKTHI FINANCE LIMITED
CIN : L65910TJ1955PLC000145
Regd. Office : 62, Dr.Nanjappa Road, Coimbatore - 641 018
Tel : (422) 2231471- 474, 4236200; Fax : (422) 2231915
E-mail : investors@sakthifinance.com
Website : www.sakthifinance.com

SPECIAL WINDOW-RE-LODGE MENT FOR TRANSFER AND DEMATERIALISATION OF PHYSICAL SECURITIES

Securities and Exchange Board of India (“SEBI”) had discontinued transfer of physical shares from 1 April 2019. However, a special window was opened by SEBI from 7 July 2025 to 6 January 2026, for re-lodgement of physical share transfer requests originally submitted before 1 April 2019 but returned due to deficiencies in documentation.

In order to facilitate the Investors, the SEBI has, by its Circular No. HO/38/13/11(2)2026-MIRSD-POD/I/3750/2026 dated 30 January 2026, decided to open another special window for one year from 5 February 2026 to 4 February 2027. While lodging request under special window for transfer of physical shares, one of the mandatory requirements is submission of original share certificate which is as follows:

Execution date of transfer deed	Lodged for transfer before 1 April 2019	Original Security Certificate Available?	Eligible to lodge in the current window?
Before 1 April 2019	No (it is fresh lodgement)	Yes	✓
	Yes (It was rejected / returned earlier)	Yes	✓
	Yes	No	x
	No	No	x

Further, the following cases will not be considered under this window:

- Cases involving disputes between transferor and transferee.
- Securities which have been transferred to Investor Education and Protection Fund (“IEPF”).

NOTE: All shares re-lodged during this period will be processed through the transfer-cum-demat route i.e. they will only be issued in dematerialised (“demat”) form after transfer and it will be subject to a lock-in for one year.

Shareholders who have missed the earlier deadline for re-lodgement of transfer deeds are once again encouraged to take advantage of this opportunity by providing the necessary documents to the Company’s Registrar and Share Transfer Agent (“RTA”), MUGF Intime India Private Limited and in case of any clarification, shareholders concerned can get in touch with the Company / RTA, at any of the addresses given below:

Sakthi Finance Limited	MUGF Intime India Private Limited
No. 62, Dr. Nanjappa Road Coimbatore - 641 018 Tel : (0422) 2231471-474, 4236200 Fax : (0422) 2231915 E-mail : investors@sakthifinance.com Website : https://sakthifinance.com/	“Surya”, 35, Mayflower Avenue Behind Senthil Nagar Sowripalayam Road Coimbatore - 641028 Tel : (0422) 2314792 / 4958995/ 2539835/36 Email : coimbatore@in.mpmf.mufig.com Website: https://in.mpmf.mufig.com/

Update of KYC and conversion of physical shares into dematerialised form:

Shareholders holding shares in physical form are encouraged to update their KYC details and convert their physical shares into demat form. Holding shares in dematerialised form offers multiple benefits and eliminates the risks associated with the physical share certificates.

For Sakthi Finance Limited
S. Venkatesh
Company Secretary and
Chief Compliance Officer
FCS 7012

QUICKLY.

Gold heads for seventh straight monthly gain



Gold prices rose on Friday as uncertainty over US tariff policies and US-Iran tensions underpinned the metal's safe-haven appeal and put it on track for a seventh straight monthly gain. Spot gold gained 0.9 per cent to \$5,232.21 an ounce by 1325GMT. US gold futures for April delivery were up 1.2 per cent at \$5,253.20. REUTERS

Copper prices hit three-week high

London: Copper prices rose on Friday and were on track for a seventh consecutive month of gains as demand optimism outweighed concerns over stocks piling up in warehouses registered with major exchanges. Benchmark three-month copper on the LME rose 1.3 per cent to \$13,472 a tonne by 1056 GMT after touching \$13,496 for its highest since February 4. REUTERS

Palm oil rises, but posts monthly drop



Jakarta: Malaysian palm oil futures inched higher on Friday on the back of Dalian edible oils strength, but posted their biggest monthly decline in 10 months due to sluggish exports and a stronger ringgit. The benchmark palm oil contract for May delivery on the Bursa Malaysia Derivatives Exchange advanced 35 ringgit to 4,040 ringgit a tonne at closing after a 1 per cent drop on Thursday. REUTERS

Crude oil heads for weekly decline

Reuters
London

Crude oil prices rose on Friday but remained on track for a weekly decline after the US and Iran extended nuclear talks, easing concern over potential hostilities that could disrupt supply, while OPEC+ could raise output at its meeting on Sunday. Brent crude futures rose 28 cents to \$71.03 a barrel by 0845 GMT while US West Texas Intermediate crude was up 42 cents, or 0.6 per cent, at \$65.63. For the week, Brent was heading for a 1 per cent decline while WTI was on track for a 1.1 per cent drop, reversing some of the previous week's gains. "Uncertainty prevails, fear is pushing prices slightly higher today," said Tamas Varga, an oil analyst at brokerage PVM.

Bay of Bengal nations set for major overhaul in small-scale fisheries governance

Our Bureau
Kochi

Fisheries governance across the Bay of Bengal region, including India, is expected get a major overhaul, with countries committing to develop National Plans of Action for the small-scale fisheries sector.

At a global meeting of the Sub-Committee on Fisheries Management (COFI-FM) held by the UN's Food and Agriculture Organisation (FAO) in Reykjavik, Iceland, the Bay of Bengal Programme Inter-Governmental Organisation (BOBP-IGO) proposed FAO-regional collaboration to transform the fisheries governance in the Bay of Bengal countries in a way that supports small-scale fisheries across India,

Poultry exports soar to a new high

STRONG GULF BUYING. Reopening of Dubai market, demand from UAE, Indonesia & Japan drive shipments

Vishwanath Kulkarni
Bengaluru

Poultry exports are set for a record this financial year on robust purchases by countries such as United Arab Emirates (UAE), Indonesia and Japan among others. The re-opening of Dubai market for Indian poultry products is also aiding the demand trend, stakeholders said.

For the first nine months of FY26, the exports have nearly doubled to a record \$237 million against \$119 million during the same period last year, as per data from the Directorate General of Commercial Intelligence and Statistics. In volume terms, the shipments have grown considerably to over 18.87 lakh tonnes (lt) over corresponding last year's 6.96 lt.

Valsan Parameswaran, Secretary, All India Poultry Exporters Association, said demand from UAE, Oman and Dubai has pushed up the exports. Dubai, which is a major consumption centre, has opened up the market for Indian poultry after a gap of about 10 years and Indian products are competitively priced compared with Turkey and Iran, he said.

NEW MARKETS

In fact, the shipment value to UAE has seen more than a three fold growth during April-December this year. UAE has displaced Oman as the largest buyer with shipment value exceeding \$92 million during April-December this year when compared to \$23.14 million a year ago period. Countries like Indonesia and Japan, which import egg powder from India

Demand driven surge
India poultry exports at new high

Financial year	Value (\$ million)	Quantity (tonnes)
2025-26 (Apr-Dec)	237.52	1,887,641
2024-25	168.77	1,034,644
2023-24	184.58	1,275,232
2022-23	134.04	664,753
2021-22	71.03	320,240

Source: DGCIIS, Apeda

have seen the demand going up during this period. "While the UAE and Oman are big markets for Indian poultry, we are also trying to establish and make inroads into the newer markets like the CIS countries, which is a very big market," said Divya Kumar Gulati, Chairman, CLFMA of India. "The confidence that we built up when we exported the eggs to the US last year is seen helping increase the

overall shipments. We have been able to comply and our quality is improving," Gulati added. Besides the Gulf, Indian poultry exports have been going on to markets like Maldives and some West African countries, Parameswaran said. "Dubai is a good market for processed chicken, but it is occupied and dominated by Brazil and getting a foothold is a challenge," he added. "Though we have been able to successfully export the eggs and egg products, we are lagging in the shipments of poultry meat as our cost of production is still high due to higher raw material cost when compared to other origins like Brazil. Though we exported a few containers to the UAE, we are unable to match the price of Brazil. This lack of export

competitiveness is what we have been discussing with the government and urging them to set up or allow on export basis like an EoU and meet price parity of raw materials so that our final products are competitive enough," Gulati said. "If we want to have exports and at the same time grow our domestic consumption, we need to have the inputs at the parity of what the world levels are. Only then we will be competitive to export our meats. Our production efficiency is much better in case of table eggs, so we are able to compete," Gulati added. India is the second largest egg producer, with production estimated at 149.11 billion, up 4.4 per cent from the previous year. The poultry industry has been growing at 7-8 per cent per annum.

Saudi Arabia's import curbs unlikely to have any impact



SMALL SHARE. Industry stakeholders said trade volumes to Saudi Arabia have historically been minimal, with Indian shipments largely directed to other markets in the region

Vishwanath Kulkarni
Bengaluru

Saudi Arabia's ban on poultry imports will not have any material impact on India's poultry sector, as the West Asian nation accounts for only a negligible share. Saudi Arabia's food safety regulator had recently banned imports of poultry meat and table eggs from 40 countries, including India, as a precaution against bird flu and other animal diseases. Industry stakeholders said that trade volumes to Saudi Arabia have historically been minimal, with Indian shipments largely directed to other markets in the region. Consequently, the restriction is not expected to disrupt domestic production, pricing, or export realisations in any meaningful way. "There will not be any impact of the Saudi ban on Indian poultry sector. Saudi is not importing from us," said Valsan Parameswaran, Secretary, All India Poultry Product Exporters Association. As per data from the Directorate General of Commercial Intelligence and Statistics, poultry exports to Saudi Arabia during 2024-25 stood at 79.74 tonnes valued at \$0.1 million, accounting

for a fraction of the overall exports. Overall poultry exports during financial year 2024-25 were over 10.34 lakh tonnes valued at \$168.77 million. **10 MILLION EGGS** India exports around 10 million eggs to West Asian countries daily, largely from Narmakkal, Tamil Nadu. "Our markets are mainly Oman, Turkey, the UAE and Qatar," Parameswaran said. The exports constitute a very small share in overall poultry meat and egg production. "This restriction on imports of poultry products by Saudi Arabia would not impact the Indian poultry sector as shipments to Saudi Arabia are limited as well as local demand and consumption are rising steadily," says Ricky Thaper, Joint Secretary, Poultry Federation of India. Thaper said the Indian poultry industry is currently valued at \$30 billion and employs 6 million people directly or indirectly. The broiler (meat purpose) bird population is 5.5 billion annually and the layer (for eggs) population is 350 millions. In addition, there are 40 million backyard birds. India is the world's largest producer of eggs with annual production of 142.6 billion.

Meghalaya to bring 1 lh under organic farming by 2028

Our Bureau
Mangaluru

Meghalaya is planning to take the total area under organic farming to 1 lakh hectares (lh) by 2028 from the existing 27,000. A statement by the Meghalaya Department of Agriculture and Farmers' Welfare said the area under organic farming increased from 18,000 hectares in 2018 to 27,000 hectares in 2025, and is projected to reach 1 lh by 2028. Strong certification systems and farmer collectives ensure quality, traceability and consistency. Mentioning that Meghalaya's spices are largely organic by default, supported by rich soils and high rainfall, the statement said the State produces over 16,000 tonnes of spices annually, with organic cultivation



STEADILY INCREASING. Agriculture's contribution to Meghalaya's GDP has more than doubled over the past six years

steadily expanding across districts. State's strategy has focused on crops that reflect Meghalaya's identity and ecological strengths, including Lakadong turmeric, ginger, black pepper, bay leaf, Kew pineapples and Khasi Mandarin oranges. **MIRACLE SPICE** The statement said the GI-

tagged Lakadong turmeric, grown in the hills of West and East Jaintia, is globally recognised for its rich colour, aroma and exceptionally high curcumin content, ranging between 7 per cent and 12 per cent. The Centre has described it as the 'Miracle Spice of Meghalaya'. Under the Lakadong mission, turmeric cultivation expanded to 2,190 hectares,

supported by more than 20 processing units that benefited over 13,000 farmers and enabled exports of dried turmeric slices. The Ginger Mission has played a key role in strengthening ginger cultivation and value addition across the State. It said over 19,000 farmers have received free ginger seeds over the last four years, helping expand production at grassroots level. In 2025 alone, 348 tonnes of ginger were processed, generating ₹1.74 crore through the sale of sliced and dried ginger, with over 1,700 farmers directly benefiting from the initiative. Highlighting that ginger and black pepper are contributing strongly to rising farm incomes, the statement said ginger production increased from 66,156 tonnes in 2018-19 to 71,413 tonnes

in 2024-25, placing Meghalaya among the top ten producers in the country. Black pepper production has grown from 801 tonnes in 2018-19 to 2,267 tonnes in 2024-25, securing a top three national ranking. In districts such as West and South Garo Hills, integrated village cooperative societies cooperatives have improved price realisation through aggregation, quality grading and direct market access. Over 420 tonnes of ginger, turmeric, black pepper, bay leaf and cinnamon were traded across domestic and export markets between 2022 and 2025. It said that agriculture's contribution to Meghalaya's GDP has more than doubled over the past six years — from ₹5,977.91 crore in 2018-19 to ₹12,332.26 crore in 2024-25.

Soluble fertilizer body seeks single portal to shorten regulatory cycle

Subramani Ra Mancombu
Chennai

The Soluble Fertiliser Industry Association (SFIA) has urged the Centre to come up with a single national digital portal for all filings of fertilizer formulations to end the practice of repeatedly seeking State-level permissions and shorten the regulatory cycle. Rajib Chakraborty, President, SFIA, told *businessline* in an online interaction that the portal should have instant system generated acknowledgements and deemed approvals after prescribed timelines. SFIA has mooted eight steps to the government think-tank NITI Aayog for reducing the fertilizer sector's efforts going round for regulatory approvals. Calling for "One Nation, One Registration", the SFIA President

said once a manufacturer or product complies with the Fertilizer (Control) Order and is duly acknowledged or approved on the Central portal, it should be valid across all States without additional registrations, annual no objection certificates or local renewals. "The advantages are clear. It eliminates duplication and inconsistent State level requirements, reduces discretion and procedural delays, and significantly lowers compliance costs especially for MSMEs and innovation driven companies," he said. Such a move will create a seamless national market, ensure uniform enforcement standards, and shorten the regulatory cycle. "Most importantly, it provides predictability and regulatory certainty, which are essential for indigenous manufacturing, R&D investment," said Chakraborty.

The digital portal should have mandatory and functional State Fertilizer Committees with industry representation, standardised documentation across States, upgraded and time-bound laboratory testing, uniform inspection protocols, and periodic performance review of States. SFIA has made suggestions for an industry-friendly regulatory framework for the sector with NITI Aayog. The association president said the framework will not dilute the standards but replace discretion and criminalisation with transparent, technology-driven and national uniform compliance. **TRUST-BASED CONTROL** The association is seeking "One Nation, One registration" of formulations to eliminate repetitive State level permissions.



Rajib Chakraborty, President, Soluble Fertiliser Industry Association

"Enforcement should clearly distinguish between minor deficiencies and deliberate fraud, moving toward graded monetary penalties instead of automatic criminal prosecution," said Chakraborty. Trust-based regulation will uphold quality while promoting ease of doing business and indigenous

manufacturing in line with the spirit of *Jan Vishwas*, he said. Stating that the fertilizer sector requires reform anchored firmly in the *Jan Vishwas Siddhant*, he said it was a governance philosophy built on trust, decriminalisation, proportionality, and technology enabled transparency. While the Fertilizer (Control) Order, 1985, has safeguarded quality standards, its continued operation under the Essential Commodities framework reflects a control-oriented mindset inconsistent with *Jan Vishwas* principles, said the SFIA President. *Jan Vishwas* calls for reducing criminal provisions, eliminating redundant compliance, and replacing discretion with digital, rule based systems. SFIA has been encouraged by the government's proact-

ive approach and it was reassuring that NITI Aayog has taken cognisance of the concerns raised by stakeholders, Chakraborty said. The government think tank invited detailed policy inputs on strengthening the regulatory framework in the sector. "This reflects a clear commitment to consultative and evidence based policymaking. This signals an intent to move toward trust based, technology enabled, and compliance driven regulation. That is a very positive development for the sector," he said. The water soluble fertilizer, organic and bio stimulant sector's products should be aligned with national priorities, such as rationalisation of fertilizer subsidies, and the broader "Nutrition for the Nation" agenda, covering soil, human and animal health, he said.

Ramadan effect softens CTC dust demand in Kochi auctions

V Sajeew Kumar
Kochi

Ramadan fasting seems to weigh on tea consumption in parts of northern Kerala, as evidenced by the subdued sales of CTC dust grades at the Kochi auctions. Traders said internal buying was limited in sale 9, which led to a rise in unsold quantities of CTC dust by around 28 per cent out of the offered 4,43,491 kg. They attributed the decline to the shutdown of hotels and tea shops in the morning hours in Muslim-dominated northern Kerala during fasting. **MIXED IMPACT** It was pointed out that Ramadan fasting creates a mixed impact on the tea industry, leading to high demand for good liquoring



varieties for Iftars, while noticing a drop in day time consumption. In the auctions, the price of good liquoring teas was down by ₹1-2 per kg, and a lot of bottomline teas remained unsold. The auctioneers Forbes, Ewart & Figgis said blenders were selective and subdued, with Kerala and upcountry buyers operating in less

strength. The orthodox dust market was also lower and witnessed some withdrawal. Anil George, Chairman of the Tea Trade Association of Cochin, said medium and plainer teas continued to undergo healthy price corrections, reflecting seasonal demand moderation during the Lenten period. However, in the orthodox market, export enquiry from the Middle East and CIS provided consistent support, while domestic buying remained selective, he said. The orthodox market was strong with 96 per cent sales out of the offered 1,71,003 kg. The Kochi market is witnessing good enquiry both from upcountry buyers and exporters, especially in the absence of tea due to crop failure across the production centres.

Godrej Agrovet expands product portfolio

Our Bureau
Kolkata

Diversified agri-business major Godrej Agrovet is expanding its product portfolio and strengthening its distribution networks in the North and the East for its crop protection business as part of its growth strategy, going forward. The company's new plant for the crop protection business in Gujarat's Dahej, which is expected to be commissioned by May this year, will manufacture newly-launched products along with existing products. "We have made a commitment that every year we will be launching one new product. Aligning to this entire business strategy, we have decided to set up the new manufacturing facility at Dahej," NK Rajavelu, CEO-Crop Protection Business, Godrej Agrovet, told the media in Kolkata on Friday. The company has two manufacturing plants in Jammu and Maharashtra.

NEW INSECTICIDE It launched a new multi-crop insecticide 'Takai'. Powered by Japanese technology, Takai offers quick control and longer-lasting protection against major lepidopteran pests, namely 'caterpillar-type' insects that damage crops, thereby helping farmers improve the overall crop health. Because of its nature of product portfolio, the company has a very strong presence in the South and West. "Around 60 per cent of our total sales are coming from the South and West. We are now improving our distribution network in the East and North," Rajavelu said. "Our strategy is to move into at least 10 major crops in the country. We are now present in five to six crops. And we are introducing new products every year to capture the market," he added.

QUICKLY.

PM to launch countrywide HPV vaccination drive

Mumbai: A countrywide Human Papillomavirus (HPV) vaccination campaign in 14 year old girls, as a protection against cervical cancer, will be launched on Saturday by Prime Minister Narendra Modi from Ajmer, Rajasthan, the Union Health Ministry said. The programme covers approximately 1.15 crore girls in the specific age group, across all States and Union Territories. **OUR BUREAU**

Glenmark set to launch sodium phosphates jabs

New Delhi: Glenmark Pharmaceuticals on Friday said its US-based unit is gearing up to introduce a generic sodium phosphates injection in the American market. The Mumbai-based drug firm said its product is therapeutically equivalent to Hosiara Inc's reference listed drug. **PM**

Smartphone shipments to hit record low in 2026 due to memory crunch

TECH STAGNATION. Slow upgrades owing to minimal technology advancements will prolong downturn till 2027

Our Bureau
Chennai

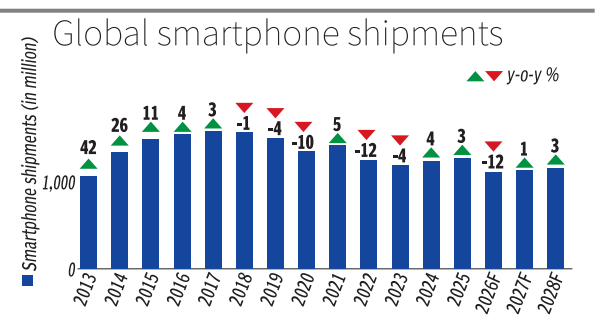
Global smartphone shipments are forecast to fall 12 per cent y-o-y in 2026, dropping just below 1.1 billion units, the lowest annual volume since 2013, when the global 4G transition was still on, research firm Counterpoint said in an analysis on Friday.

A severe memory crunch, coupled with elongated replacement cycles in absence of large specification changes are set to be the primary trigger of the downturn, which is anticipated to extend into 2027.

"Premium segments will remain comparatively resilient, while lower segments will face the sharpest margin and affordability pressures

due to shrinking LPDDR4 supply and rising component costs. As a result, OEMs focused on lower segments and emerging markets will take the biggest hit," Counterpoint said.

LONG TERM DELAYS
Counterpoint Principal Analyst Yang Wang said, "The impact is expected to continue through H2 2027, as it will take several quarters for memory supply expansion to materialise. Lower-end smartphones are likely to be affected the most, especially as LPDDR4 supply is shrinking faster than expected. OEMs are already responding with launch delays, streamlined portfolios and specification trade-offs. We have also observed 10-20 per cent price increases across some Android OEM portfo-



Source: Counterpoint Research Market Monitor & Market Outlook Services
February 2026 update; Based on shipments/sell-in

lios in January 2026."

"Apple and Samsung are likely to weather the headwinds better due to stronger supply chain integration, higher pricing power, and continued premiumisation," Counterpoint said.

"We also expect the second-hand smartphone market to grow in 2026 as some of these offerings in

the sub \$300 segment will look more attractive to budget-conscious buyers," the report added.

SHIPMENT DECLINE
Speaking to *businessline* about the scenario in Indian smartphone market, Counterpoint senior analyst Prachir Singh said that there is a 5-10 per cent shipment de-

cline in India due to the memory crunch. OEMs are either passing on the higher memory prices to consumers or in some instances there is a sort of "Shrinkflation" with trade off of specs in subsequent models, he said. The memory crunch is fundamentally supply-side in nature, and recovery will depend on the pace of new memory capacity coming online, he added.

Manufacturers continue to divert the wafer capacity toward higher-margin AI-focused DRAM needs such as those in data centres, and this leaves smartphone OEMs with limited visibility. Mobile LPDDR4/5 prices in Q2 2026 are expected to reach nearly three times the levels seen in Q3 2025, reflecting an unprecedented squeeze in supply.

Unacademy unveils ₹50 cr ESOP buyback plan amid broader strategic overhaul

Our Bureau
Bengaluru

Edtech firm Unacademy has initiated a ₹50 crore ESOP buyback programme, offering liquidity to current and former employees at a time when the company is navigating a broader strategic reset and valuation correction.

Announcing the move on X, Co-founder and CEO Gaurav Munjal said, "We just started the 50 cr ESOPs buy back for our team members. This is our way of ensuring that people who helped us build Unacademy are rewarded for their efforts."

He added, "Though the valuation is much lower than the last fund raise, still we are trying to do right by our team, in whatever way we can."

According to Munjal, eight employees will receive over ₹1 crore each under the buyback. Seventeen will make more than ₹50 lakh, and 38 more than ₹10 lakh. In a subsequent post, he noted that more than 25 team members will receive ₹50 lakh or more.

CASH POOL

"Thanks to the Board for creating this Cash Pool so that the team members who were with us in the past can reap some monetary benefits," he said.

The buyback comes months after acquisition talks with upGrad fell through over valuation differences. Unacademy was reportedly seeking a valuation of \$300-400 million for the deal. Earlier discussions with K-12 Techno Services also did not materialise.

Once valued at \$3.5 billion, Munjal said in December that the start-up's valuation may have fallen to below \$500 million amid a funding winter and post-



Eight employees will receive over ₹1 crore each under the buyback. Seventeen will make more than ₹50 lakh, and 38 more than ₹10 lakh, says Munjal

pandemic slowdown in edtech. Unacademy has raised over \$830 million from investors including Peak XV Partners, SoftBank, WaterBridge Ventures and Meta.

OFFLINE BUSINESS

The company is also exiting its offline business by converting company-operated centres into franchise partnerships.

In an internal e-mail last month, Munjal said the franchise model would enable a more asset-light and capital-efficient structure, with the transition expected to be completed by April.

Founded in 2015 by Munjal, Roman Saini and Hemesh Singh, Unacademy evolved from a YouTube channel into a major test-prep and upskilling platform. While it is yet to report FY25 numbers, the company narrowed its standalone net loss by 82 per cent to ₹285 crore in FY24, even as operating revenue dipped marginally to ₹716 crore.

Air India targets FY27 growth with upgrades, partnerships

Rohit Vaid
New Delhi

Tata Group-led Air India is aiming to convert operational improvements and product upgrades into measurable commercial growth in fiscal year 2027 (FY27), a senior airline official said.

Accordingly, Nipun Aggarwal, Chief Commercial Officer, Air India, described FY27 as a strategic inflection point for the airline, emphasising the goal of turning recent investments and operational enhancements into tangible results.

"With a strengthened fleet and upgraded services, we are positioned to expand our reach, improve connectivity, and deliver a more seamless

experience for our passengers," he said in an internal Friday post to employees which was reviewed by *businessline*.

Besides, the airline plans to expand its footprint with new international destinations from Delhi and Mumbai while optimising domestic hubs.

CONNECTIVITY FOCUS

Notably, the focus on connectivity includes enhancing domestic-to-international and international-to-international transfers to ensure smoother journeys across the network.

Apart from network expansion, Air India is leveraging strategic partnerships, premium cabin upgrades, customer-centric initiatives,



SEAMLESS NETWORK. Focus on connectivity includes boosting domestic-to-international and international-to-international transfers to ensure smoother journeys

and artificial intelligence (AI)-driven decision frameworks to strengthen commercial performance.

Furthermore, loyalty programmes, including the Maharaja Club, are being integrated across the group to enhance customer retention and drive revenue growth.

According to Aggarwal,

FY26 was one of the most challenging years in the airline's recent history. Airspace closures across Pakistan, Iran and Iraq, geopolitical volatility affecting demand, and the tragic AI171 incident created significant operational headwinds.

Despite these challenges,

the airline stabilised operations, protected its network, and continued advancing its transformation agenda. "Periods like these clarify who we are as an organisation," said a company spokesperson.

UPGRADED INTERIORS

Looking ahead, FY27 is focused on acceleration rather than recovery. The narrow-body retrofit programme is complete, delivering consistent cabin standards, upgraded interiors, enhanced in-flight amenities and elevated service.

Additionally, domestic net promoter scores have grown 10-fold over the past two years. On the wide-body side, the first line-fit Boeing 787-9, designed specifically for Air

India, began operations on the Mumbai-Frankfurt route. By the end of 2026, 20 additional wide-body aircraft, including retrofitted legacy 787s and new Airbus A350-1000s, will carry the upgraded product across Europe, North America, and the Far East.

Air India is also prioritising operational reliability. Aggarwal pointed out that schedule consistency, proactive disruption management, and seamless connectivity are critical, particularly for corporate clients.

Extended flight times due to airspace constraints have heightened misconnection risks, necessitating proactive planning and customer support.

Industry lambasts 'one-sided' session on 2027 EV mandate

Ronendra Singh
New Delhi

A meeting of an expert committee established by the Commission for Air Quality Management (CAQM), held on Friday to discuss mandating EVs for taxis by 2027 and private cars by 2030 in the NCR region, ended in a stalemate after a stormy session with industry representatives. According to industry sources, the chairman of the committee, Ashok Jhunjhunwala from IIT Madras, appeared "dismissive" of their views. They noted that the meeting failed to be productive because it lacked two-way discussion, resulting in the chairman dominating the floor. When contacted, Jhunjhunwala refused to comment on the proceedings.

"We do not talk to the press about CAQM internal meetings," Jhunjhunwala

told *businessline*. The industry representatives had a lot of grievances about the meeting.

"Although the meeting was convened to gather industry views and provide clarifications, it devolved into a one-sided conversation. When we inquired whether the CAQM possessed any studies or data to support mandating EVs by next year, they offered no response. Similarly, they were unable to provide a scientific basis or any reports regarding the adequacy of public charging infrastructure," an industry representative, who was part of the meeting, told *businessline*.

MITIGATION PLANS

Industry representatives said they acknowledge the severity of Delhi's air pollution but wanted to emphasise in the meeting the need for practical mitigation

strategies. Their argument is that an EV mandate is not a standalone solution for the region's air quality issues. "But there was no reasonable discussion on this," said an industry source.

Industry representatives tried to underline that regulations such as Bharat Stage-6 and Corporate Average Fuel Efficiency (CAFE) norms, and other technologies like CNG and hybrid vehicles are available, primarily for the purpose of bringing down pollution.

However, the CAQM committee is understood to be considering a proposal to allow only zero tailpipe emission (ZTE) four-wheeler taxis, effectively zero-emission vehicles, be registered in Delhi-NCR from April 1, 2027, and all private vehicles too ZTEs from April 2030.

With inputs from Sindhu Hariharan in Chennai

Netflix drops bid, Paramount wins Warner Bros deal

Bloomberg

Netflix dropped out of the fight to buy Warner Bros Discovery, clearing the way for rival bidder Paramount Skydance to clinch its \$111 billion deal for the historic Hollywood studio.

"The transaction we negotiated would have created shareholder value with a clear path to regulatory approval," Netflix said on Thursday.

"However, we've always been disciplined, and at the price required to match Paramount Skydance's latest offer, the deal is no longer financially attractive, so we are declining to match the Paramount Skydance bid."

The streaming industry leader inked an \$82.7 billion deal, including assumed debt, to acquire the businesses in December.

Warner Bros deemed the latest Paramount offer superior on Thursday.

Abbott in deal to sell a second brand of Novo Nordisk's diabetes drug Ozempic

PT Jyothi Datta
Mumbai

Multinational Abbott is partnering with Novo Nordisk India to commercialise Extensor, as a second brand of Ozempic, for treating people living with type 2 diabetes.

Novo Nordisk had in December brought its globally-popular Ozempic, reportedly the world's most prescribed GLP-1 RA (receptor agonist) molecule, to India.

KEY PARTNERSHIP

Separately, it had also inked a partnership with Emcure for a second brand of its weight-loss product Wegovy.

This segment is seeing increased activity as a patent on semaglutide, the active ingredient in Ozempic and Wegovy, expires later next month in many markets, including India.

Abbott distributes both

Ozempic and Wegovy in India, but this is the first time it is marketing the product under its brandname, an industry-insider pointed out.

While details on how it will be priced are not available, it will be pegged possibly lower than the originator's price, the industry-source told *businessline*, adding that prices could drop further, as the patent on semaglutide expires. The product will be available in a FlexTouch pen — a once-weekly device that provides precise dosing in 0.25 mg, 0.5 mg and 1 mg dose strengths, Abbott said.

Novo's weekly price, announced at launch, were 0.25mg at ₹2,200, 0.5mg at ₹2,542 and 1mg at ₹2,794.

RISK REDUCTION

Semaglutide has also demonstrated powerful HbA1c reduction, compelling weight-loss benefits, and proven risk reduction of cardiovascular

and kidney events in people with type 2 diabetes, it added.

Kartik Rajendran, Managing Director, Abbott India Ltd, said, "The launch of Extensor builds on Abbott's longstanding focus on holistic diabetes management — from medicines to diagnostics, and from continuous glucose monitoring to diabetes specific nutrition. Developed and manufactured by Novo Nordisk, this brand will be commercialised by Abbott," it added.

DIABETES CARE

Vikrant Shrotriya, Managing Director, Novo Nordisk India, said, "Semaglutide represents one of the most significant scientific advancements in diabetes care in recent decades. It has changed the way type 2 diabetes is managed, offering meaningful improvements in metabolic, renal and cardiovascular health."

Indonesia stops mega order of Indian trucks

Bloomberg

Indonesia is halting an order for 105,000 trucks from India's Tata Motors Ltd and Mahindra & Mahindra Ltd following pushback from policymakers.

Imports of the vehicles, a mix of 4x4s and six-wheeler trucks slated for use in President Prabowo Subianto's drive to establish more than 80,000 community cooperatives across the archipelago nation, will be put on hold pending a meeting between the government and lawmakers, Cooperatives Minister Ferry Juliantono said in an interview with a local TV station late Thursday.

Pausing is "the right step to avoid further controversy," he said.

"And when the time comes, we will be able to sit down together to find the best solution," Ferry Juliantono said.

Norway wealth fund exits Adani Green stake

Press Trust of India
New Delhi

Norway's \$1.2 trillion sovereign wealth fund, the world's largest, has decided to exclude Adani Green Energy Ltd (AGEL) from its portfolio due to concerns about its alleged links to financial crime.

Norges Bank, which had in May 2024 excluded Adani Ports and Special Economic Zone Ltd, on its website added AGEL to the list of companies that it has decided to exclude from its portfolio.

It cited "gross corruption or other serious financial crime" as the criterion for its decision but gave no explanation.

When Norges Bank first bought AGEL shares in July 2020, the share price was ₹341. Today it is ₹944.

T20 World Cup boosts travel demand as fans flock to host cities

Cricket fever drives a significant surge in flight and stay bookings, delivering a major lift to tourism

Rohan Das
Chennai

With the T20 World Cup 2026 in full swing, domestic travel has picked up pace as travel companies report a significant surge in flight and stay bookings to locations that are playing host to the matches.

According to data from home sharing company Airbnb, searches for check-ins at several match-hosting cities during the cricket season rose nearly 2x compared to the same period last year.

MARQUEE VENUE

Ahmedabad, a marquee venue with the largest stadium in the country, posted a 170 per cent y-o-y rise in searches for stays between

March 7-10, when the final of the World Cup is set to take place.

Interestingly, the demand has not been restricted to key metro hubs but also to smaller, tier-2 cities. Ranchi saw nearly a 120 per cent increase in searches while Thiruvananthapuram recorded over 110 per cent growth. Jaipur and Lucknow witnessed increases of over 70 per cent and 60 per cent respectively. The surge was also seen in flight and hotel bookings to the match hosting cities.

As per data sourced by *businessline* from EaseMyTrip, air travel bookings to host cities across February and March have increased by around 25-30 per cent year-on-year as compared to non-cricket weeks



FAN FRENZY. Spectators cheering during the ICC Men's T20 World Cup match between India and Zimbabwe at the MAC Stadium in Chennai on Thursday

last year. Similarly, hotel searches for match-day windows have seen an uptick of about 20-25 per cent

Rikant Pittie, CEO and Co-Founder of EaseMyTrip, said that for tier-2 cities, the

y-o-y search uptick on the platform was more than 100 per cent, with some of them reaching 'peak season' volumes recurring or around the match days.

Though short-term in

nature compared to religious tourism or summer holidays, these trips typically extend beyond just the match day.

LOCAL CULTURE

"Rather than short, single purpose visits, these trips are often built as longer stays as more than half the users extend trips beyond match days to explore local culture, cuisine and neighbourhoods," said Amanpreet Singh Bajaj, Airbnb's Country Head for India and Southeast Asia.

The demand for cricket tourism is also being driven by a younger traveller base.

Pittie said that the platform had nearly 60 per cent of sports-related bookings coming from travellers under 30.

China Eastern to expand ops to Mumbai from May

Anees Phadnis
Mumbai

Mumbai will get direct air connectivity to China in the summer with China Eastern Airlines planning four weekly services from Shanghai. China Eastern Airlines is likely to start the service from May with an Airbus A330 aircraft. The airline is also looking to restart flights between Kunming and Kolkata in the summer.

Flights between India and China resumed last October after a five-year gap. From India, IndiGo and Air India operate flights to Guangzhou (from Delhi and Kolkata) and Shanghai (from Delhi). China Eastern Airlines resumed its Shanghai-Delhi service last November with three weekly frequencies, which was scaled to a

daily flight from January. A source said the route is performing well with loads upwards of 80 per cent. In addition to point-to-point traffic, the airline is also seeing passengers travelling onward to Japan and Korea.

"The Mumbai-Shanghai flights will enhance connectivity to China and beyond," said Anil Kalsi, Board Member, Federation of Associations in Indian Tourism and Hospitality.

ONLINE VISA

India began issuing e-visas to Chinese nationals last July in a sign of normalisation of ties. China, too, introduced an online visa application system in India last December to speed up processing.

Over three lakh Indians travelled to China in CY2025, data released by the Tourism Ministry show.

Company	Prev	Close	Open	High	Low	Qty	52 WH	52 WL	PE	BSE
Pix Transim	1445.20	1451.80	1445.90	1466.00	1435.00	9.35	1799.60	1220.10	-	-
Platinumind	226.20	222.14	226.03	226.21	218.02	108.52	242.00	213.00	-	-
PH Gadgil Jw	544.50	522.00	544.00	556.56	544.00	96.64	96.01	473.80	-	-
PNB	74.20	74.80	74.80	75.60	74.60	18.75	71.80	71.55	6	79.93
PNB Housing	84.70	84.75	84.670	84.75	84.10	767.21	1141.85	74.80	10	828.80
PNC Infra [2]	211.67	206.79	212.99	212.99	205.26	45.16	131.30	205.20	15	206.40
PNC Indus Ltd [2]	23.45	906.20	906.20	916.00	906.20	1.00	140.00	906.20	-	-
Poly Medicus [5]	125.88	126.10	126.50	127.90	122.90	37.12	296.70	122.85	25	127.60
Polycab Ind	8596.00	86150.00	8602.00	8722.00	8489.00	926.90	927.00	4555.00	-	-
Polyplex	39.53	848.30	839.00	829.00	825.80	243.83	1396.70	77.50	40	844.95
PONAM F&C	44.20	454.80	454.00	464.00	446.30	1.00	14.00	454.80	-	-
Pondy Oxydes	1164.50	126.00	116.00	116.40	121.10	205.54	198.00	490.00	-	-
Ponni Superph	26.05	272.90	267.05	275.35	265.35	38.54	368.75	253.50	12	272.50
Power Finance	90.75	95.35	90.75	96.06	88.75	196.84	151.80	83.00	-	-
Power Finar	42.60	41.80	42.00	42.95	41.60	6922.37	43.35	30.05	7	41.85
Power grid	303.25	238.65	305.80	305.80	297.10	2140.68	32.75	247.50	18	292.75
Power Infra	103.25	103.98	104.27	106.89	103.05	4.07	216.00	103.70	-	-
Power Indus	163.96	166.52	163.00	168.50	163.00	110.79	206.90	134.85	12	166.40
POWERMECH	211.55	207.90	212.50	212.50	206.65	67.17	345.45	169.85	21	207.95
Prabha Ener	176.91	174.36	175.51	182.30	173.90	28.59	31.95	164.47	-	-
Prabha Ind Ltd [2]	31.75	31.75	31.75	31.75	31.75	1.00	31.75	31.75	37	317.90
Prakash Ind	13.74	13.16	13.50	13.80	13.30	10.67	11.90	11.00	7	13.10
Prakash Pipe	203.70	205.05	203.70	209.17	200.80	37.61	437.90	186.41	-	-
Prakash Pwr	138.05	26.00	20.00	28.60	20.00	1.00	20.00	26.00	46	136.30
Precision W [1]	306.96	312.25	305.98	320.99	303.16	176.73	320.50	118.35	44	312.00
Premier Ent	72.25	73.10	72.25	74.10	72.50	580.62	1163.90	660.00	-	-
Premier Exp [2]	54.90	53.75	53.75	54.60	52.75	25.57	82.88	30.95	62	53.75
Prime Focus	131.60	131.60	131.60	131.60	131.60	1.00	131.60	131.60	-	-
Princal Ltd [1]	61.70	60.20	61.70	61.90	59.90	32.48	69.45	38.150	47	60.15
Prime Cement	26.51	25.84	26.01	26.99	25.32	315.05	294.84	85.00	-	-
Prism Focus [1]	126.15	125.77	125.05	127.45	124.75	13.31	172.15	108.00	-	-
Prism Cement	299.70	303.29	299.00	304.90	297.00	97.22	344.90	136.15	-	-
Prism Indus	1145.00	1145.00	1145.00	1145.00	1145.00	1.00	1145.00	1145.00	-	-
Prostamind	58.55	59.00	59.00	60.50	58.85	177.63	184.50	58.00	-	-
Prudent Corp	248.80	249.50	245.10	246.50	235.60	48.00	180.00	157.00	-	-
Prudent Ind	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	1.00	179.40	179.40	-	-
PTC Ind	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	1.00	179.40	179.40	-	-
PTC Ind [2]	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	1.00	179.40	179.40	-	-
PTC Ind [3]	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	1.00	179.40	179.40	-	-
PTC Ind [4]	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	1.00	179.40	179.40	-	-
PTC Ind [5]	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	1.00	179.40	179.40	-	-
PTC Ind [6]	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	1.00	179.40	179.40	-	-
PTC Ind [7]	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	1.00	179.40	179.40	-	-
PTC Ind [8]	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	1.00	179.40	179.40	-	-
PTC Ind [9]	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	1.00	179.40	179.40	-	-
PTC Ind [10]	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	1.00	179.40	179.40	-	-
PTC Ind [11]	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	1.00	179.40	179.40	-	-
PTC Ind [12]	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	1.00	179.40	179.40	-	-
PTC Ind [13]	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	1.00	179.40	179.40	-	-
PTC Ind [14]	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	1.00	179.40	179.40	-	-
PTC Ind [15]	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	1.00	179.40	179.40	-	-
PTC Ind [16]	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	1.00	179.40	179.40	-	-
PTC Ind [17]	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	1.00	179.40	179.40	-	-
PTC Ind [18]	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	1.00	179.40	179.40	-	-
PTC Ind [19]	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	1.00	179.40	179.40	-	-
PTC Ind [20]	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	1.00	179.40	179.40	-	-
PTC Ind [21]	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	1.00	179.40	179.40	-	-
PTC Ind [22]	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	1.00	179.40	179.40	-	-
PTC Ind [23]	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	1.00	179.40	179.40	-	-
PTC Ind [24]	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	1.00	179.40	179.40	-	-
PTC Ind [25]	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	1.00	179.40	179.40	-	-
PTC Ind [26]	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	1.00	179.40	179.40	-	-
PTC Ind [27]	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	1.00	179.40	179.40	-	-
PTC Ind [28]	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	1.00	179.40	179.40	-	-
PTC Ind [29]	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	1.00	179.40	179.40	-	-
PTC Ind [30]	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	1.00	179.40	179.40	-	-
PTC Ind [31]	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	1.00	179.40	179.40	-	-
PTC Ind [32]	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	1.00	179.40	179.40	-	-
PTC Ind [33]	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	1.00	179.40	179.40	-	-
PTC Ind [34]	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	1.00	179.40	179.40	-	-
PTC Ind [35]	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	1.00	179.40	179.40	-	-
PTC Ind [36]	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	1.00	179.40	179.40	-	-
PTC Ind [37]	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	1.00	179.40	179.40	-	-
PTC Ind [38]	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	1.00	179.40	179.40	-	-
PTC Ind [39]	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	1.00	179.40	179.40	-	-
PTC Ind [40]	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	1.00	179.40	179.40	-	-
PTC Ind [41]	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	1.00	179.40	179.40	-	-
PTC Ind [42]	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	1.00	179.40	179.40	-	-
PTC Ind [43]	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	1.00	179.40	179.40	-	-
PTC Ind [44]	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	1.00	179.40	179.40	-	-
PTC Ind [45]	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	1.00	179.40	179.40	-	-
PTC Ind [46]	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	1.00	179.40	179.40	-	-
PTC Ind [47]	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	1.00	179.40	179.40	-	-
PTC Ind [48]	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	1.00	179.40	179.40	-	-
PTC Ind [49]	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	1.00	179.40	179.40	-	-
PTC Ind [50]	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	1.00	179.40	179.40	-	-
PTC Ind [51]	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	1.00	179.40	179.40	-	-
PTC Ind [52]	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	1.00	179.40	179.40	-	-
PTC Ind [53]	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	1.00	179.40	179.40	-	-
PTC Ind [54]	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	1.00	179.40	179.40	-	-
PTC Ind [55]	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	1.00	179.40	179.40	-	-
PTC Ind [56]	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	1.00	179.40	179.40	-	-
PTC Ind [57]	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	1.00	179.40	179.40	-	-
PTC Ind [58]	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	1.00	179.40	179.40	-	-
PTC Ind [59]	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	1.00	179.40	179.40	-	-
PTC Ind [60]	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	1.00	179.40	179.40	-	-
PTC Ind [61]	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	1.00	179.40	179.40	-	-
PTC Ind [62]	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	1.00	179.40	179.40	-	-
PTC Ind [63]	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	1.00	179.40	179.40	-	-
PTC Ind [64]	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	1.00	179.40	179.40	-	-
PTC Ind [65]	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	1.00	179.40	179.40	-	-
PTC Ind [66]	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	1.00	179.40	179.40	-	-
PTC Ind [67]	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	1.00	179.40	179.40	-	-
PTC Ind [68]	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	1.00	179.40	179.40	-	-
PTC Ind [69]	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	1.00	179.40	179.40	-	-
PTC Ind [70]	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	1.00	179.40	179.40	-	-
PTC Ind [71]	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	1.00	179.40	179.40	-	-
PTC Ind [72]	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	1.00	179.40	179.40	-	-
PTC Ind [73]	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	1.00	179.40	179.40	-	-
PTC Ind [74]	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	1.00	179.40	179.40	-	-
PTC Ind [75]	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	179.40	1.00	179.40			